

Site 136: 19-17/32/1

‘IRAQ ER-RESIFEH (5)

Israel grid: 1932/1720	Soil quality: 6
UTM grid: 7317/5589	Cultivation: none
Elevation: 110 m a.s.l., 0 m a.s.a.	Cisterns: none
Name: nearest place	Water source: Wadi Far’ah (104),
Site type: enclosures	2.5 km distant
Area: 3 dunams (3000 sq. m)	Road: Jiftlik–Tana (C35), 200 m
Topography: plateau	distant
Rock type: Avdat Group	Visit: March 1995; 47 sherds
Soil type: stony-desert	

A site of enclosures in the western margins of the ‘Iraq er-Resifeh plateau, between the sites of er-Resifeh (1) and er-Resifeh (2), about 4 km south-east of Mekhora.

The remains of three enclosures were found:

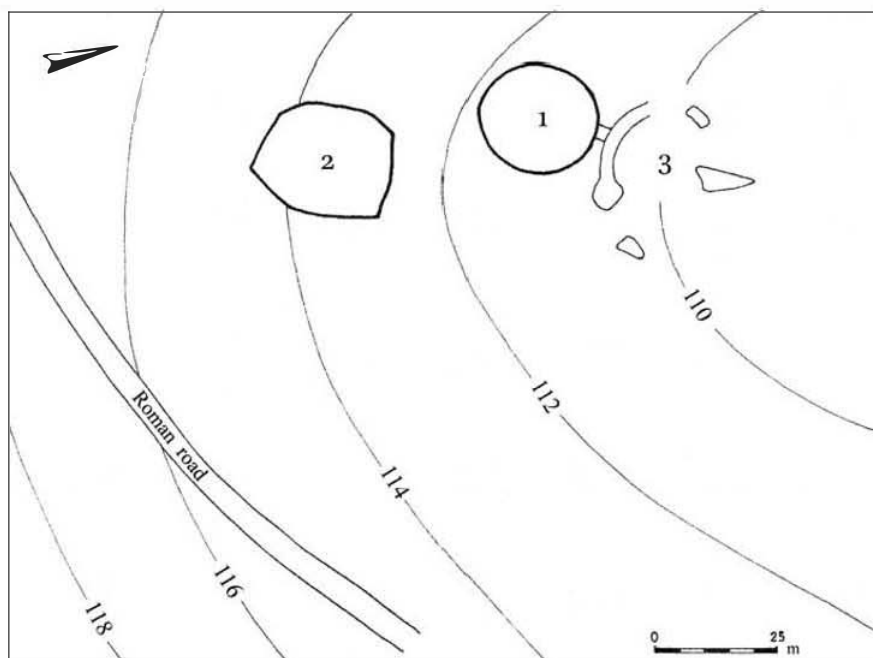
1. In the northern part of the site is a round enclosure, 18 m in diameter, with a surrounding wall built of one row of large stones. Inside and next to it are sherd scatters. Adjacent to the west are the partial remains of another enclosure.
2. In the centre of the site is an especially large enclosure about 35 m in diameter. The surrounding wall is similar in masonry to enclosure no. 1. Inside are the remains of two smaller enclosures: one is rather square in shape and is 12 m across, and the other is partly visible with an irregular shape, about 9 m across. We cannot tell if all these enclosures were used at the same time.
3. Slightly to the east are the partial remains of two small rounded structures. Other walls are scattered in the north-eastern part of the site, and attest to other structures.

About 40 m south of the site is a built Roman road, a section of the Jiftlik–Tana–Neapolis road (C35).

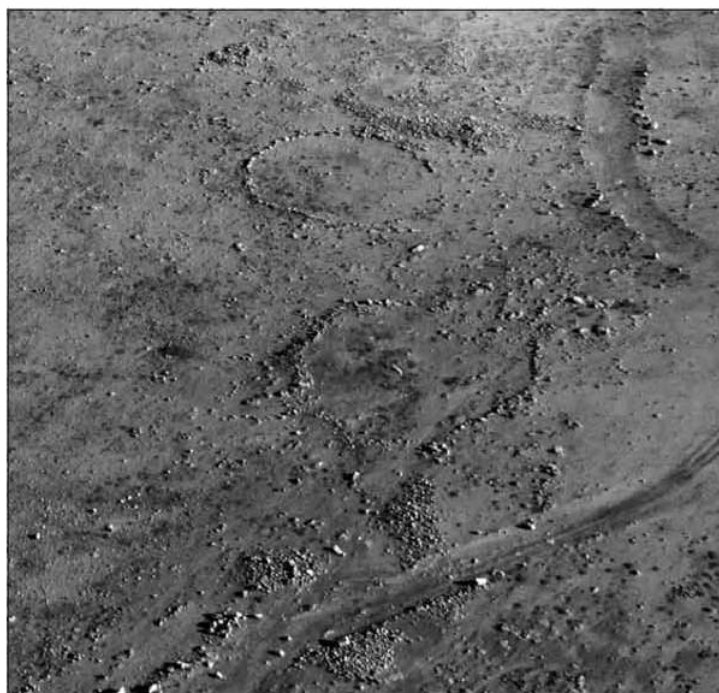
The sherd scatter in the site differs from that of ‘Iraq er-Resifeh (2), and therefore it has been decided to distinguish it from the nearby sites.

Pottery: Late Roman – 81%; Byzantine – 15%; Modern – 4%.

Additional surveys: none.



274. Plan of 'Iraq er-Resifeh (5), 2013.



275. Aerial view to the north of 'Iraq er-Resifeh (5), 2013 (A. Solomon).

Site 137: 19-17/11/3

JEBEL EL-MAḤJARAH (3)

Israel grid: 1910/1712

UTM grid: 7295/5580

Elevation: 280 m a.s.l., 100 m a.s.a.

Name: nearest place

Site type: cave and courtyard

Area: 1 dunam (1000 sq. m)

Topography: slope

Rock type: Avdat Group

Soil type: brown-forest

Soil quality: 3

Cultivation: none

Cisterns: none

Water source: 'Ein Abu Daraj (177),
1 km distantRoad: Jiftlik–Ṭana (C35), 500 m
distant

Visit: Nov. 2001, 28 sherds

A small site, in the northern high part of Jebel el-Maḥjarah, about 500 m east of the unpaved Sartaba–Mekhora road, close to a small valley ascending to the east. There is a fine view from it to Mekhora and Wadi Zeith.

The site has two main parts:

1. A built courtyard, measuring about 30×10 m with its two short legs attached to the rocky cliff to the south. A platform of large stones elevates the courtyard about 6 m above the valley. The upper part of the platform ramp was formed by a double wall about 1.5 m thick built from medium-sized stones, and the space between them was filled with earth.
2. Along the low cliff to which the courtyard is attached are three small



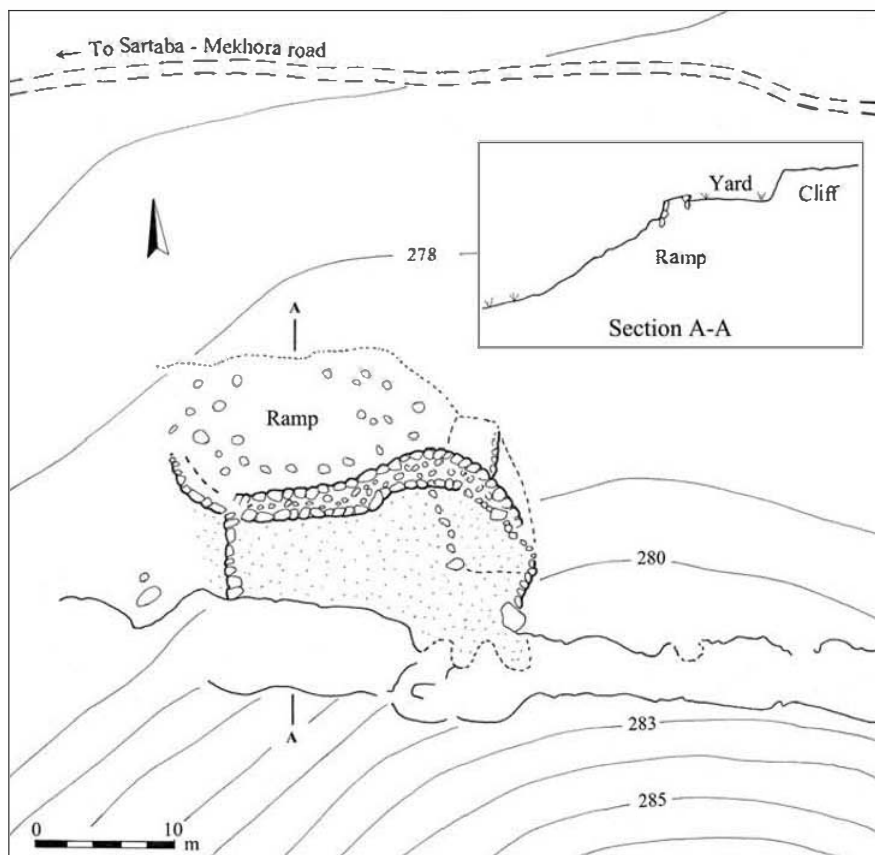
276. Jebel el-Maḥjarah (3), view to the west, 2001. In the background is Sartaba–Mekhora road, and behind it is Jebel el-Maḥjarah ridge (M. Einav).

caves less than 3 m deep. The charred ceilings of the caves testify to animal husbandry in them. To the north, in the valley close to the site, is an unpaved road.

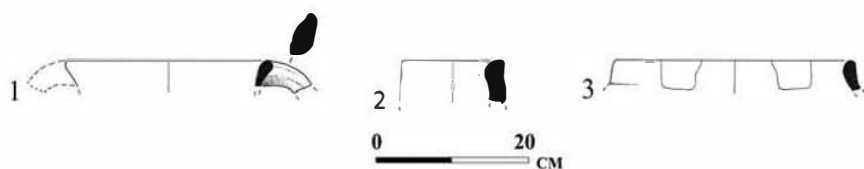
Pottery: Iron II – 18%; Late Roman – 71%; Middle Ages – 11%.

Flint: 39 items, Middle Palaeolithic, see Appendix A.

Additional surveys: none.



277. Plan of Jebel el-Mahjarah (3), 2001.



278. Pottery from Jebel el-Mahjarah (3): 1. Jug, lt brn, LR; 2. Juglet, brn, Ir II; 3. Krater, dk brn, Ir II.

Site 138: 19-17/●1/1

JEBEL EL MAḤJARAH (1)

Israel grid: 19●5/171●

UTM grid: 7289/5578

Elevation: 3●● m a.s.l., 3● m b.s.a.

Name: nearest place

Site type: enclosure

Area: ●.5 dunam (5●● sq. m)

Topography: high saddle

Rock type: Avdat Group

Soil type: brown-forest

Soil quality: 4

Cultivation: none

Cisterns: none

Water source: 'Ein Abu Daraj (177),
1.1 km distant

Road: Jiftlik-Ṭana (C35), 1 km distant

Visits: June 1994, Nov. 2●●1; 38 sherds

A round enclosure 21 m in diameter in a saddle over a high wide spur in the el-Mahjadrah ridge, 3.5 km south of Mekhora. A road which ascends to the Sartaba passes the site. There is a broad view to the Mekhora Valley and Wadi Far'ah in the north, and to Gittit in the west.

The enclosure is located in a pool-like hollow, and is encircled by a wall built from medium-sized fieldstones. To the west is a rock-cut basin with a groove to accommodate a lid. Around the enclosure are scattered sherds.

The site may also have served as a seasonal reservoir for rain water.

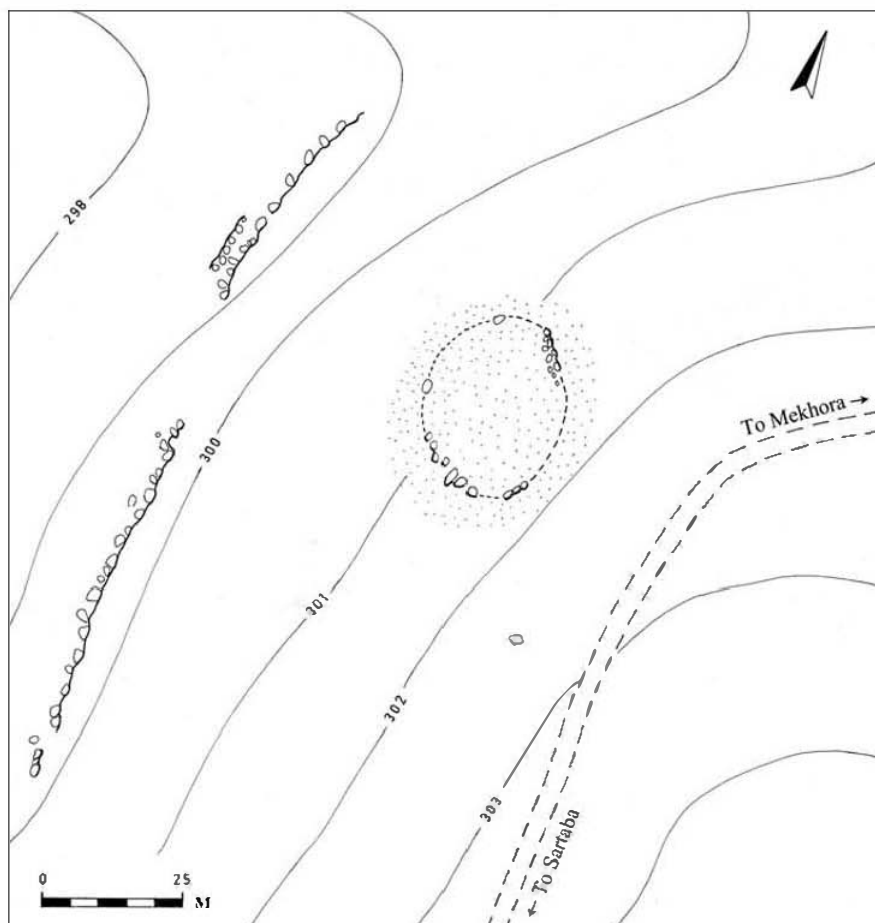
Pottery: Iron II – 27%; Hellenistic – 5%; Late Roman – 42%; Ottoman – 26%.

Flint: 27 items, Middle Palaeolithic, see Appendix A.

Additional surveys: none.



279. Jebel el Maḥjarah (1) enclosure, view to the north-west, 2001 (M. Einav).



280. Plan of Jebel el Mahjarah (1), 2001.

Site 139: 19-17/21/2

JEBEL EL MAḤJARAH (5)

Israel grid: 1922/1711	Soil quality: 3
UTM grid: 7308/5580	Cultivation: none
Elevation: 120 m a.s.l., 0 m a.s.a.	Cisterns: none
Name: nearest place	Water source: 'Ein Abu Daraj (177),
Site type: enclosures	1.9 km distant
Area: 5 dunams (5000 sq. m)	Road: Jiftlik-Ṭana (C35),
Topography: spur over slopes	next to the site
Rock type: Avdat Group	Visit: July 1994; 6 sherds
Soil type: desert-lithosol	

A site on a narrow spur on a slope descending south-east from E.P. 280 summit to the upper basin of Wadi Jaber. The site is 4 km south-east of Mekhora.

In the centre of the site is an irregularly-shaped enclosure, 13×8 m. Part of it is built of large standing stones, and the rest is of medium-sized stones. To the north-east are attached three or four badly damaged structures, built of medium-sized square stones. These structures may have served as dwellings.

Up the spur are agricultural terraces, courtyards and the possible remains of a camp site.

There are very few sherds in the site.

Pottery: Late Roman (?) – 100%.

Additional surveys: none.



Site 140: 19-17/11/4

WADI JABER (1)

Israel grid: 1916/1710	Soil quality: 6
UTM grid: 7301/5579	Cultivation: none
Elevation: 220 m a.s.l., 90 m a.s.a.	Cisterns: none
Name: nearest place	Water source: 'Ein Abu Daraj (177),
Site type: courtyards	1.2 km distant
Area: 30 dunams (3 ha)	Road: Jiftlik-Ṭana (C35), 500 m
Topography: spur on a moderate slope	distant
Rock type: Avdat Group	Visit: July 1994; 41 sherds
Soil type: stony-desert	

A large site on a spur on a moderate slope descending south to Wadi Jaber from E.P. 280, about 4 km south-east of Mekhora.

The site is spread over several spurs and slopes at various levels, but its hub is at the above coordinates. In this area were found at least three large courtyards, encircled by walls of medium-sized stones, one stone thick, and one stone-built terrace. Threshing floors and built circles were also visible.

It looks as if the site served alternately as a camping place for semi-nomads, and as a centre for cereal growing in good rainy years.

Pottery: Iron I – 7%; Iron II – 19%; Hellenistic – 7%; Late Roman – 30%; Byzantine – 24%; Middle Ages – 10%; Ottoman – 3%.

Stone: a complete grinding stone and three basalt fragments.

Additional surveys: none.



Site 141: 19-17/11/5

JEBEL EL-MAHJARAH (4)

Israel grid: 1915/1712

UTM grid: 7300/5581

Elevation: 270 m a.s.l., 40 m a.s.a.

Name: nearest place

Site type: farm

Area: 1 dunam (1000 sq. m)

Topography: hilltop over a slope

Rock type: Judea Group

Soil type: stony-desert

Soil quality: 4

Cultivation: none

Cisterns: none

Water source: 'Ein Abu Daraj (177),
1.5 km distant

Road: Jiftlik–Tana (C35), 500 m
distant

Visit: July 1994; 92 sherds

A small site on the north-eastern slope of Jebel el-Mahjarah, descending to a broad saddle west of E.P. 280. There is a good view to the Mekhora Valley, Wadi Farah, Wadi Zeith and Wadi Jaber.

In the centre of the site is an oval stone structure (4×3 m), built of medium-sized stones. Attached to it in the west is an oval courtyard or threshing floor, measuring 12 m (east-west) by 10 m (north-south). The enclosing wall, surviving mostly in its northern part, is built two rows of medium-sized stones. In its western part and parallel to it is another wall about 7 m long.

About 5 m south-west of the courtyard, are two round stone structures which may have served as silos or barns.

Pottery: Iron I-II – 13%; Late Roman – 50%; Byzantine – 37%.

Additional surveys: none.

Site 142: 18-17/90/1

WADI KHELLAL EL-FAL (3)

Israel grid: 1898/1704	Soil quality: 4
UTM grid: 7283/5572	Cultivation: none
Elevation: 170 m a.s.l., 60 m a.s.a.	Cisterns: none
Name: nearest place	Water source: 'Ein Abu Daraj (177), 1.2 km distant
Site type: farm and dwelling cave	Road: Fasa'el-Ṭana (C40), 500 m distant
Area: 1.5 dunams (1500 sq. m)	Visit: Nov. 1994; 19 sherds
Topography: shoulder	
Rock type: Avdat Group	
Soil type: brown lithosol	

A site on a shoulder descending from the Sartaba range to the valley of Wadi Afjeam, about 4 km north-east of Gittit.

The site is built on terraces on the slope; on the highest one are remains of courtyards. A built stone circle, perhaps a silo, abuts three of the terraces.

North-east across the valley is a dwelling cave about 10 m deep. The cave ceiling is charred. In the debris in front of the entrance were found many sherds, identical to those in the site.

Pottery: Late Roman – 16%; Middle Ages – 63%; Modern – 21%.

Additional surveys: none.



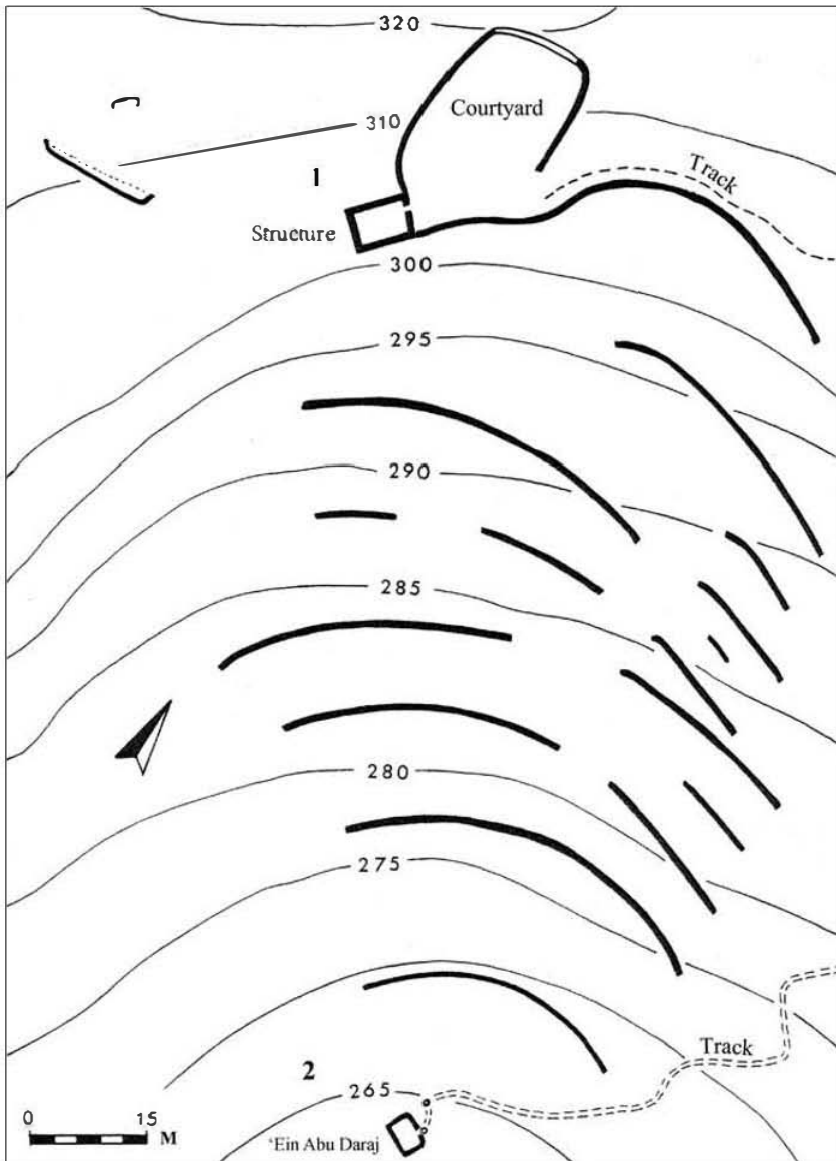
Site 143: 19-17/10/1

'EIN ABU DARAJ (1)

Israel grid: 1910/1700 (the structure)	Soil quality: 4
UTM grid: 7295/5568	Cultivation: none
Elevation: 300 m a.s.l., 100 m a.s.a.	Cisterns: none
Name: ancient but not on map	Water source: 'Ein Abu Daraj (177), at the site
Site type: spring and structures	Road: Wadi Jaber (C39), next to the site
Area: 20 dunams (2 ha)	Visit: July 1994; 83 sherds
Topography: slope	
Rock type: Avdat Group	
Soil type: stony-desert	

A complex of a spring and structures in a deep valley, in the north-western part of the Sartaba range. The location is on a slope descending south from E.P. 367, about 4 km north-east of Gittit. An unpaved road ascends eastward above the site from the Mekhora-Gittit road to the Sartaba and then descends through Wadi Jaber.

There are two main parts to the site: the structure and the spring.



281. Plan of 'Ein Abu Daraj (1), 1994.

1. On a steep slope descending to the spring at the north is a rectangular stone structure, measuring 8x6 m, with an opening facing north-east. It is built of medium-sized stones, with walls about 80 cm thick.

An oval courtyard measuring about 30x20 m abuts the structure on the north-eastern side. The encircling wall is about 40 cm (one stone) wide. About 35 m south of the structure is a large cave with a wall in front of it (not on the plan). The slopes beneath the structure, on the way to the spring, have ancient terrace walls. Some may have been built during the IA, and some in the Roman period.

2. Around the spring (at coordinates 1909/1699) are the remains of a few walls: their dating is difficult to determine, but they appear not to be modern. Some were elements of pools or small aqueducts, and others served to protect the spring vicinity against erosion and blocking with sediment.

In Markus (1992: 110) is a geological description of the spring: "The water spouts from the Eocene limestone aquifer, the aquiclude of which is a Pliocene *Taqiyā* formation. The spring exits from a small cavity dug in the worn limestone rock, and the water flows through a plastic pipe about 10 m long into an elliptical collecting pool, measuring 4x3x1.5-2 m. The small volume of water (30 litres per hour) is just enough to cover the pool floor."

At the time of our visit (1994) the pool was found to have been destroyed by floods.



232. The structure in the northern part of 'Ein Abu Daraj (1) site, view to the west,

1995.

Pottery: Iron II – 50%; Late Roman – 48%; Modern – 2%.

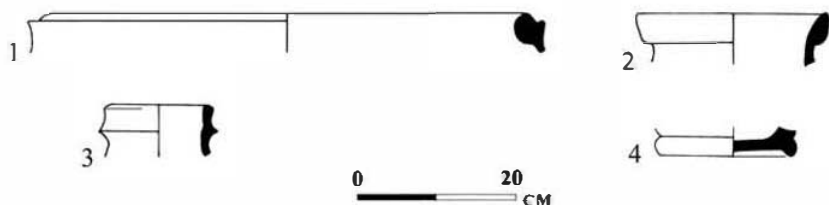
Flint: 46 items, Middle Palaeolithic and IA II, see Appendix A.

Additional surveys: none.



283. General view to the south of the 'Ein Abu Daraj spring, 1994.

The spring is at bottom left.



284. Pottery from 'Ein Abu Daraj (1): 1. CP, brn, Ir II; 2-3. Jugs, lt brn, LR; 4. Jug base, Ir II.

Site 144: 19-17/10/2

WADI JABER (2)

Israel grid: 1911/1701

UTM grid: 7350/5568

Elevation: 365 m a.s.l., 100 m a.s.a.

Name: nearest place

Site type: structures and enclosures

Area: 2 dunams (2000 sq. m)

Topography: hilltop in a high saddle

Rock type: Avdat Group

Soil type: desert lithosol

Soil quality: 3

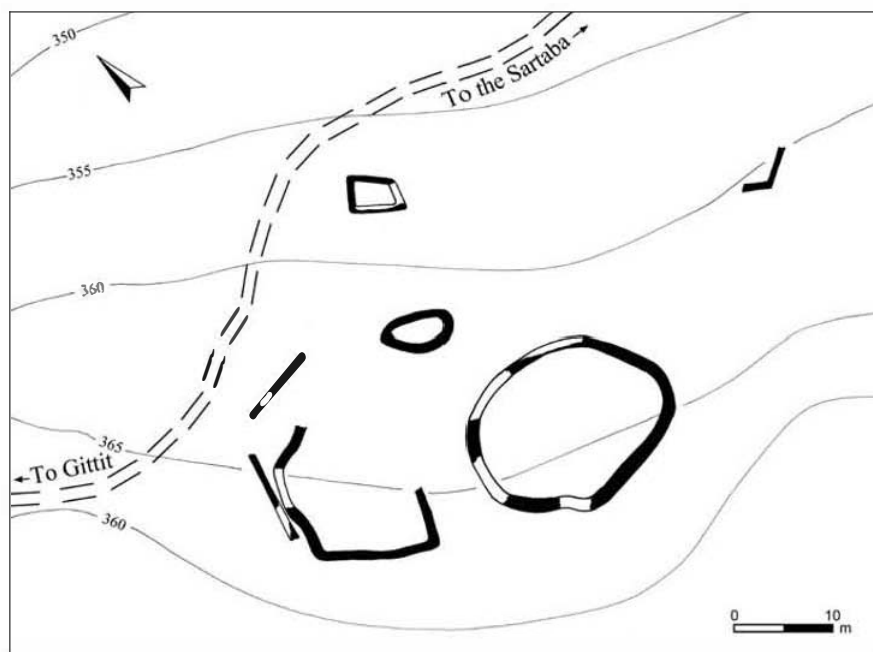
Cultivation: none

Cisterns: none

Water source: 'Ein Abu Daraj (177),
500 m distantRoad: Wadi Jaber (C39), next to the
site

Visit: July 1994; 41 sherds

A site on a hilltop at the margins of the Sartaba range, close to an unpaved road which descends from Jebel el-Mahjarah to Wadi Jaber, and then ascends to the Sartaba cone. The site is next to the high saddle between Wadi Jaber in the east and Wadi Khellal el-Fal in the west; about 4.2 km south-south-east of Mekhora. There is a view from the site to the 'Ein Abu Daraj spring and fort and the Wadi Jaber area. Close to it in the south are two modern stone houses.

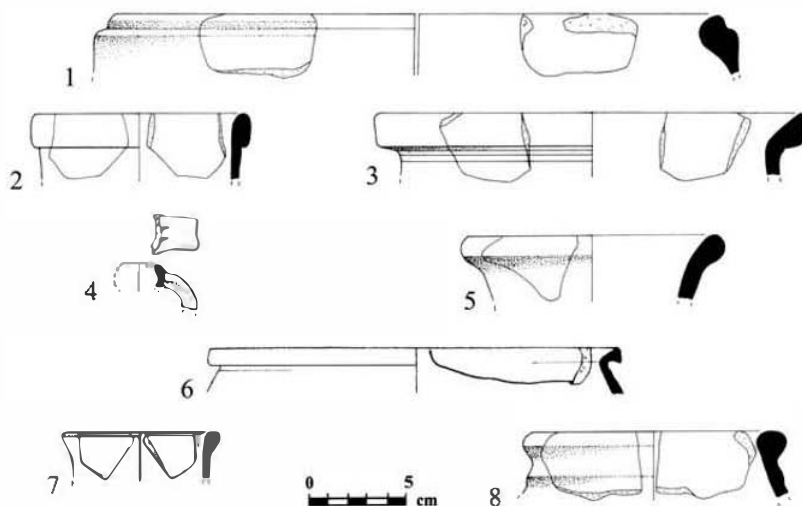


285. Plan of Wadi Jaber (2), 1994.

In the centre of the site are two courtyards whose encircling walls are built of medium-sized stones. The eastern courtyard is oval, measuring 12×8 m, and the western one is incomplete, and seems to have been square.



286. Wadi Jaber (2) site, view to the south-east, 1994. The human figures are in the enclosure and the jeep is on the road leading south to the Sartaba.



287. Pottery from Wadi Jaber (2): 1. CP, dk brn, Ir II; 2. Jar, dk brn, LR; 3. CP, dk brn, Ir I; 4. Juglet, lt brn, Ir II; 5. Jar, lt brn, Ir II; 6. CP, brn, Ir I; 7. Jug, pk, LR; 8. Jar, dk brn, Ir II.

In the northern part of the site are two small stone structures, which appear to be fairly new. At the southern and eastern parts other ancient well-built walls of medium-sized stones have been preserved.

The commanding location of the site, the fact that most of its existence was in the IA, and the great number of sherds found, link it to the nearby site of the 'Ein Abu Daraj fort (Site 154). It is likely that the site protected the road and spring, and its positioning hints at the linkage to the Sartaba already in the IA period. The utilization of the site during the Roman period seems to be secondary.

Pottery: Iron I – 10%; Iron II – 80%; Late Roman – 10%.

Additional Surveys: none.



Site 145: 19-17/20/1

WADI JABER (3)

Israel grid: 1921/1705

UTM grid: 7305 /5573

Elevation: 90 m a.s.l., 10 m a.s.a.

Name: nearest place

Site type: enclosures

Area: 2 dunams (2000 sq. m)

Topography: shoulder on a slope

Rock type: Avdat Group

Soil type: desert lithosol

Soil quality: 4

Cultivation: none

Cisterns: none

Water source: 'Ein Abu Daraj (177),

1.2 km distant

Road: Wadi Jaber (C39), 500 m distant

Visit: Feb. 1995; 22 sherds

Enclosures on a spur shoulder descending north and east from Umm Hajar ridge, south of Wadi Jaber.

In the area were found enclosures and a sherd scatter.

Pottery: Iron II – 23%; Hellenistic (?) – 9%; Early Roman – 32%; Late Roman – 18%; Byzantine – 9%; Middle Ages – 9%.

Additional Surveys: none.

Site 146: 19-17/40/1

WADI UMM HAJAR (2)

Israel grid: 1948/1705	Soil type: silt
UTM grid: 7333 /5574	Soil quality: 5
Elevation: 190 m b.s.l., 0 m a.s.a.	Cultivation: none
Name: nearest place	Cisterns: none
Site type: farm	Water source: Wadi Far'ah (104), 2 km distant
Area: 2 dunams (2000 sq. m)	Road: Wadi Jaber (C39), 400 m distant
Topography: valley margins and wadi exit	Visit: March 1995; 23 sherds
Rock type: Avdat Group	

The site is at the exit of Wadi Umm Hajar, at the margins of the Sartaba range and above the Wadi Far'ah floodplain; located about 2 km north-west of Masu'a.

There is a small structure in the site, measuring 2×2 m, built of medium-sized stones. Beside it were found three built threshing floors, 13–14 m in diameter, and 30 m west of the structure is another threshing floor. Around the structure and threshing floors were found scattered sherds in moderate numbers.

Pottery: Late Roman – 83%; Modern – 17%.

Flint: 13 items, undefined, see Appendix A.

Additional Surveys: none.



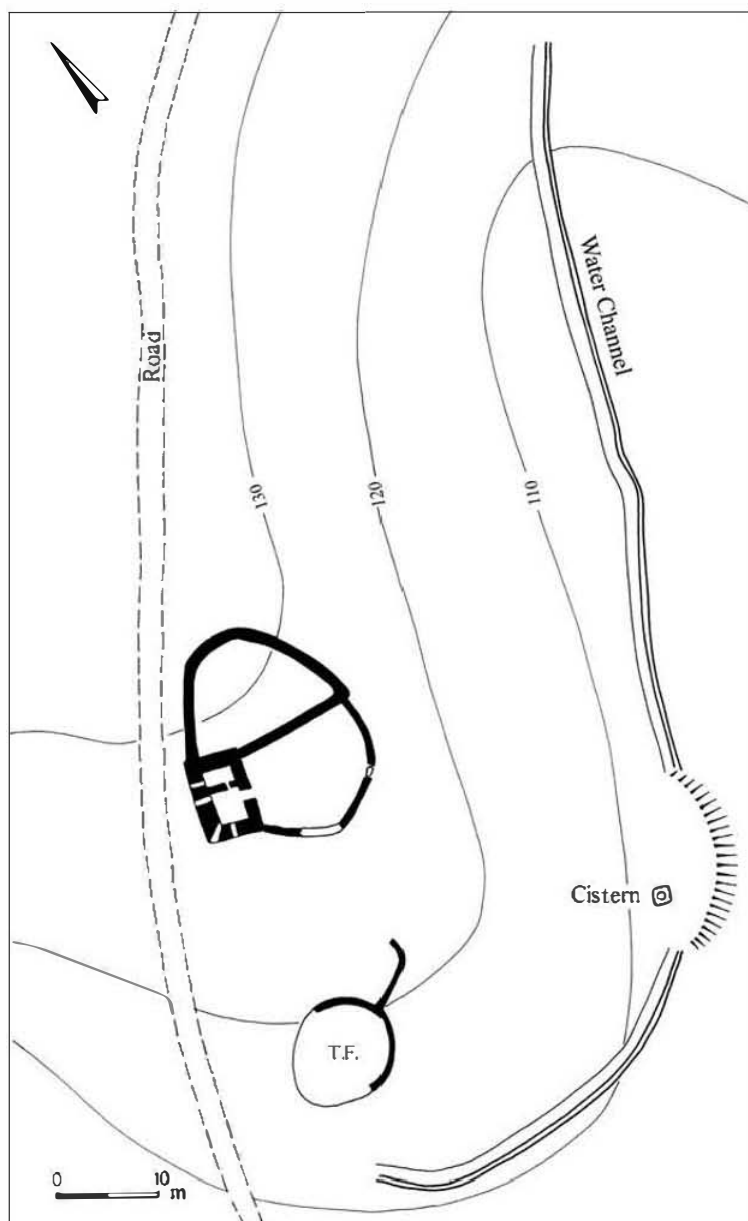
Site 147: 18-16/99/2

WADI KHELLAL EL-FAL (2)

Israel grid: 1896/1697	Soil quality: 3
UTM grid: 7281 /5565	Cultivation: none
Elevation: 130 m a.s.l., 60 m a.s.a.	Cisterns: 1
Name: nearest place	Water source: 'Ein Abu Daraj (177), 1.3 km distant
Site type: structure	Road: Fasa'el-Ṭana (C40), 700 m distant
Area: 1 dunam (1000 sq. m)	Visit: Nov. 1994; 130 sherds
Topography: spur	
Rock type: Avdat Group	
Soil type: desert lithosol	

A small site on a spur which descends northwards to the valley of Wadi Afjeam and to the Alon road, located 3 km north-east of Gittit; an unpaved road ascends nearby to the Sartaba.

In the centre of the site is a structure 8×6 m, divided into two rooms, the southern one connecting to the courtyard through an opening. The walls are



233. Plan of Wadi Khellal el-Fal (2), 1994.



289. Aerial view to the east of Wadi Khellalel-Fal (2), 2013 (A. Solomon).

about 1 m thick, with windows surviving. The structure is dry-built stone, and the walls are preserved four courses high. The structure connects to two irregular courtyards, both 12 m across, with an encircling wall preserved two courses high. They have a shared wall, from the north-eastern corner of the structure.

About 20 m south of the structure and the courtyards is a circular built threshing floor about 8 m in diameter. A dug and built cistern 30 m south-east of the above complex, on the slope which descends to the wadi-bed, is fed by two aqueducts, one on each side of the slope.

The variety and number of sherds indicate a long period of usage of the complex.

Pottery: Iron II – 34%; Late Roman – 33%; Middle Ages – 33%.

Stone: roller stone for flattening roofs.

Additional Surveys: none.

Site 148: 18-16/99/1

WADI KHELLAL EL-FAL (1)

Israel grid: 1896/1697	Soil quality: 6
UTM grid: 7281 /5566	Cultivation: none
Elevation: 130 m a.s.l., 40 m a.s.a.	Cisterns: none
Name: nearest place	Water source: 'Ein Abu Daraj (177),
Site type: farm	1.4 km distant
Area: 1 dunam (1000 sq. m)	Road: Fasa'el-Ṭana (C40),
Topography: spur and shoulder	600 m distant
Rock type: Avdat Group	Visit: Nov. 1994; 37 sherds
Soil type: brown lithosol	

A small farm on a spur north of Wadi Khellal el-Fal, 3 km north-east of Gittit.

In the centre of the site is an irregular courtyard built of large stones, measuring 23×12 m. The southern wall is straight, with two walls leading north out of its eastern and western ends. Outside the eastern side, attached to the yard wall, are two long rooms. In the north-western side abutting the courtyard, is a structure measuring 8×4 m. Another long structure inside the courtyard is part of its south-western corner. All these rooms are now heaps and rows of stones, but were undoubtedly structures.

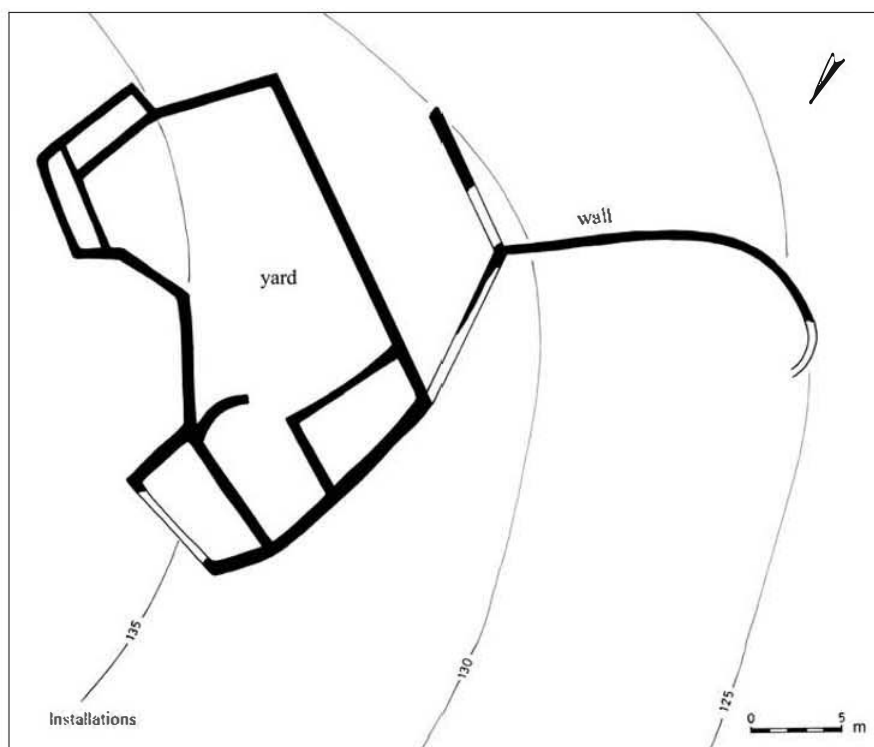
A wall extends southward from the south-western corner of the courtyard, perhaps a component of another courtyard. From this wall another wall extends about 25 m westward along the spur. About 10 m north-west of the courtyard are karstic pits, serving perhaps as troughs. 40 m east of the structure is a rock-cut basin, 60 cm in diameter.

Near the courtyard is a circular threshing floor about 10 m in diameter, partially rock-cut and partially constructed.

This site is a good example of a farm with most of its components.

Pottery: Iron II – 51%; Late Roman – 30%; Modern – 19%.

Additional Surveys: none.



290. Plan of Wadi Khellal el-Fal (1), 1994.



Site 149:18-16/99/3

E.P. 173 (1)

Israel grid: 1895/1692

UTM grid: 7281 /556●

Elevation: 1●● m a.s.l., 2● m a.s.a.

Name: nearest place

Site type: courtyard and terraces

Area: 1 dunam (1●●● sq. m)

Topography: slope and valley margins

Rock type: Avdat Group

Soil type: brown lithosol

Soil quality: 4

Cultivation: none

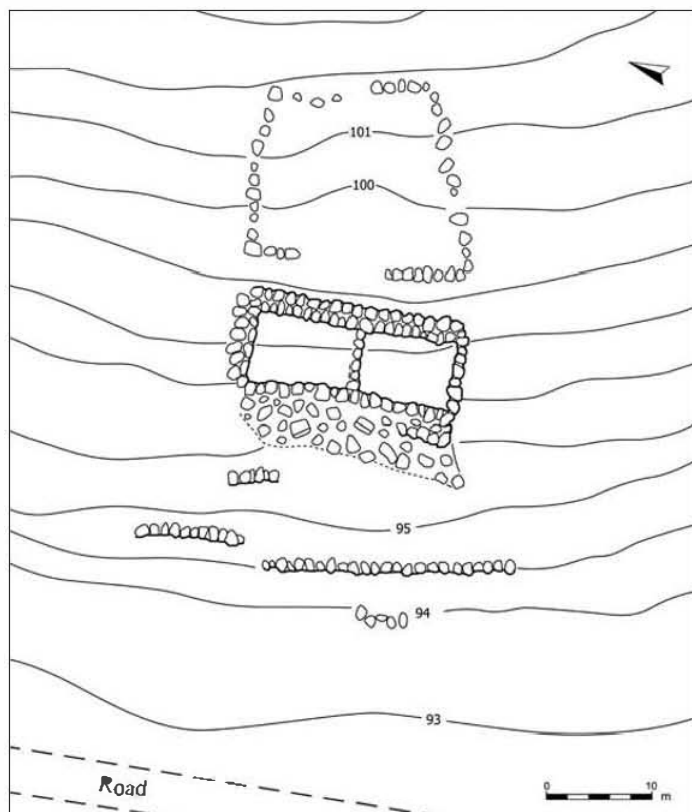
Cisterns: 1

Water source: 'Ein Abu Daraj (177),
1.6 km distant

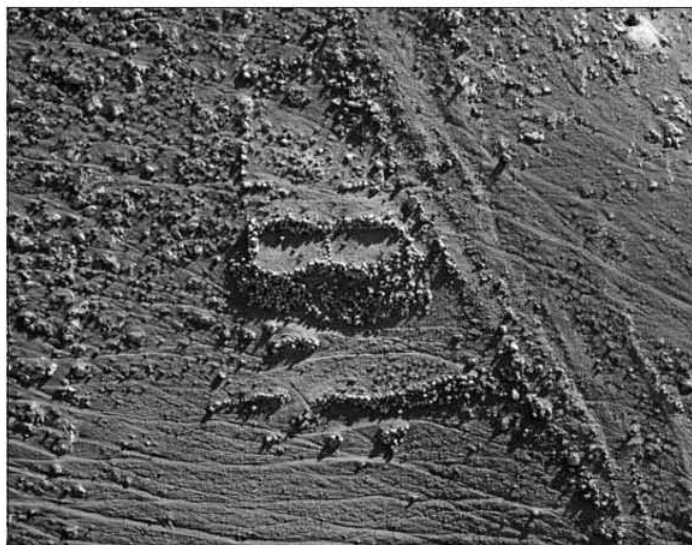
Road: Fasa'el-Ṭana (C4●), 3●● m
distant

Visits: Nov. 1994, 2●●5; 5● sherds

A small site on the western slope of E.P. 173, about 2.5 km north-east of Gittit. Gittit water reservoir now stands on the hill. The unpaved road from the Alon



291. Plan of E.P. 173 (1), 2005.



292. Aerial view to the east of E.P. 173 (1), 2013 (A. Solomon).



293. A dry construction structure close to E.P. 173 (2), 1994. Structures like this one are common on the western side of the Sartaba massif.

road crosses its northern slope and ascends to the Sartaba.

The site contains an irregular courtyard measuring about 20×12 m, built of large stones. A wall in the middle of the courtyard divides it into two. Adjacent to the east are the remains of another mostly destroyed rectangular courtyard, measuring about 19×17 m. Its north-western wall continues in the same direction as the north-western wall of the first courtyard, suggesting a connection between the two structures.

On the slope at the foot of the better preserved courtyard are two terraces that perhaps served the courtyard as supporting walls on the steep slope. About 50 m further south is a constructed cistern.

Pottery: Iron II – 6%; Late Roman – 20%; Byzantine – 26%; Early Moslem – 30%; Ottoman-Modern – 18%.

Flint: 88 items, see Appendix A.

Additional Surveys: none.

Site 150: 18-16/99/4

E.P. 173 (2)

Israel grid: 1899/1692	Soil quality: 5
UTM grid: 7284 /5560	Cultivation: field crops (partial)
Elevation: 173 m a.s.l., 120 m a.s.a.	Cisterns: none
Name: nearest place	Water source: 'Ein Abu Daraj (177), 1.2 km distant
Site type: encampment	Road: Fasa'el-Ṭana (C40), 500 m distant
Area: 4 dunams (4000 sq. m)	Visit: Nov. 1994; 48 sherds
Topography: broad hilltop	
Rock type: Avdat Group	
Soil type: brown lithosol	

A site on the hilltop of E.P. 173, south-east of Gittit water reservoir, and about 2.5 km north-east of Gittit. It looks out to the valley of upper Wadi Ahmar, through which the Alon road passes.

The area has been badly damaged by bulldozers, seemingly during the construction of the reservoir. Over the entire zone are remains of walls, small stones, several stone heaps and a stone circle about 20 m in diameter.

North of these, close to the road which ascends to the Sartaba, were found enclosing walls, possibly belonging to a ruined square courtyard. At its south-western corner is a 20 cm-diameter cupmark. The remains of a paved road were also found.

Over the entire area were found cup marks and karstic troughs for collecting rain water for livestock.

Pottery: Chalcolithic/Early Bronze I – 16%; Iron I-II – 16%; Late Roman – 33%; Byzantine – 8%; Middle Ages – 20%; Modern – 7%.

Additional surveys: none.

Bibliography: Bar 2014a: site 68.

Site 151: 19-16/●9/2

E.P. 195 (2)

Israel grid: 19●4/1694

UTM grid: 7289 /5562

Elevation: 15● m a.s.l., 6● m a.s.a.

Name: nearest place

Site type: courtyard and prehistoric

Area: 3 dunams (3●●● sq. m)

Topography: moderate spur

Rock type: Avdat Group

Soil type: desert lithosol

Soil quality: 5

Cultivation: none

Cisterns: none

Water source: 'Ein Abu Daraj (177),

8●● m distant

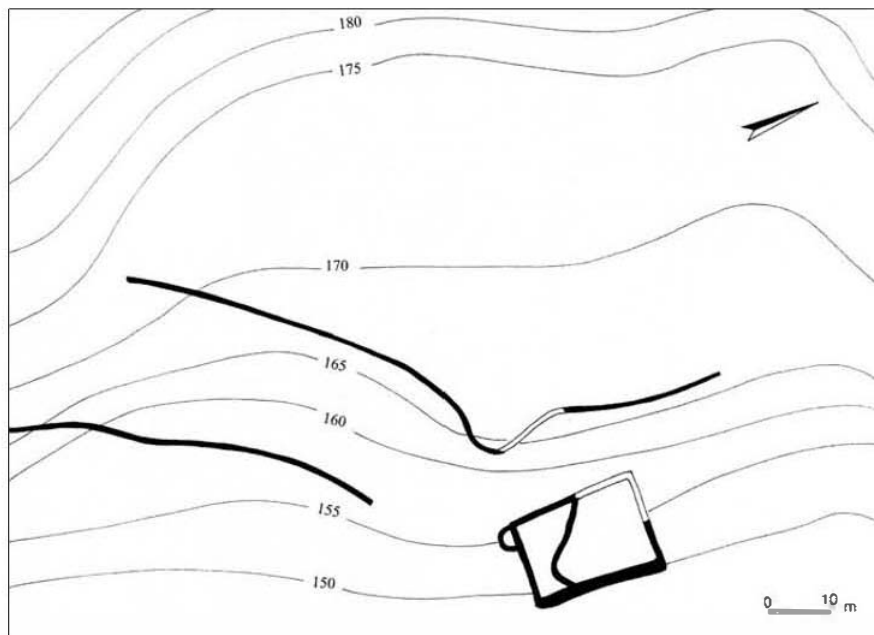
Road: Wadi Jaber (C39), 3●● m distant

Visit: Jan. 1995; 34 sherds

A site on the western slopes of the Sartaba range, on a moderate spur south of Wadi Khellal el-Fal, about 3 km north-east of Gittit. The unpaved road which ascends from the Alon road to the Sartaba passes close by.

The site is on the southern slope below E.P. 195. Most of the area of the slope is terraced: the site is on one of these terraces.

In the site is a courtyard measuring 2●×15 m, built of large stones, divided by an irregular inner wall: a few sherds were gathered in and around it.



294. Plan of E.P. 195 (2), 1995.

A prehistoric site existed here, alongside the neighbouring Site 153.

Pottery: Iron II – 21%; Late Roman – 32%; Byzantine – 35%; Middle Ages – 12%.

Flint: (together with Site 153): 378 items, Middle and Upper Palaeolithic, see Appendix A.

Additional surveys: none.



Site 152: 19-17/10/3

WADI JABER (4)

Israel grid: 1916/1709

UTM grid: 7301 /5578

Elevation: 210 m a.s.l., 40 m b.s.a.

Name: nearest place

Site type: sherd scatter and enclosures

Area: 15 dunams (1.5 ha)

Topography: slope

Rock type: Avdat Group

Soil type: brown forest

Soil quality: 5

Cultivation: none

Cisterns: none

Water source: 'Ein Abu Daraj (177),

1.2 km distant

Road: Wadi Jaber (C39), 500 m distant

Visit: May 2002; 55 sherds

A site on a small hilltop, one of a number of hilltops on the slope which descends south to the Wadi Jaber drainage basin.

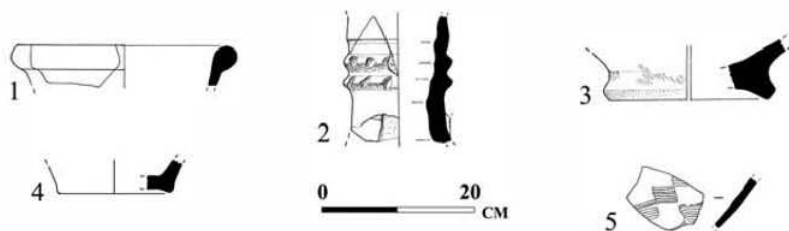
On the hilltop, surrounded by ravines in all directions, were found the remains of a 20 m-diameter round enclosure. Next to it are the remains of other enclosures, built on the lower steps. About 150 m to the north across the wadi channel are more enclosures.

The enclosure construction is primitive, using local stones. In the enclosure area is a moderate sherd scatter.

This is a site of seasonal enclosures, resembling other sites in the region. About 200 m east is a terraced hilltop, testifying to continuous agriculture in the area.

Pottery: Iron II – 7%; Hellenistic – 6%; Late Roman – 80%; Early Moslem/Middle Ages – 4%; Modern – 3%.

Additional surveys: none.



295. Pottery from Wadi Jaber (4): 1. Jar, brn, Ir II; 2. Jug, plastic dec, gr, MA; 3. Bowl base, buff, Ir II; 4. Bowl base, lt brn, Rom; 5. Wavy combed dec sherd, gr, EM-MA.



Site 153: 19-16/●9/1

E.P. 195 (1)

Israel grid: 19●2/1694

UTM grid: 7287/5563

Elevation: 195 m a.s.l., 1●● m a.s.a.

Name: nearest place

Site type: prehistoric

Area: 1 dunam (1●●● sq. m)

Topography: spur top

Rock type: Avdat Group

Soil type: desert lithosol

Soil quality: 2

Cultivation: none

Cisterns: none

Water source: 'Ein Abu Daraj (177),
8●● m distant

Road: Wadi Jaber (C39), next to the
site

Visit: Jan. 1995

A prehistoric site at the edge of E.P. 195 hilltop, on the western slope of the Sartaba range, about 3 km north-east of Gittit. Close to the site the unpaved road ascends to the Sartaba and 'Ein Abu Daraj.

There is a considerable scattering of flint items over the site surface. Their variety is significant: there is a notable presence of flint cores and manufacturing debris. There is also much flint breaking through the limestone rock: this was probably the source of the raw material for local production.

The site integrates well into the Middle Palaeolithic activity in the Sartaba range. Several Roman period sherds and a single Chalcolithic sherd with a rope decoration were also found. It is likely that the sherds came from the site on the nearby E.P. 173 hilltop (Site 15●).

Flint: (together with Site 151): 378 items, Middle and Upper Palaeolithic, see Appendix A.

Additional surveys: none.

Site 154: 19-16/19/1

'EIN ABU DARAJ FORT

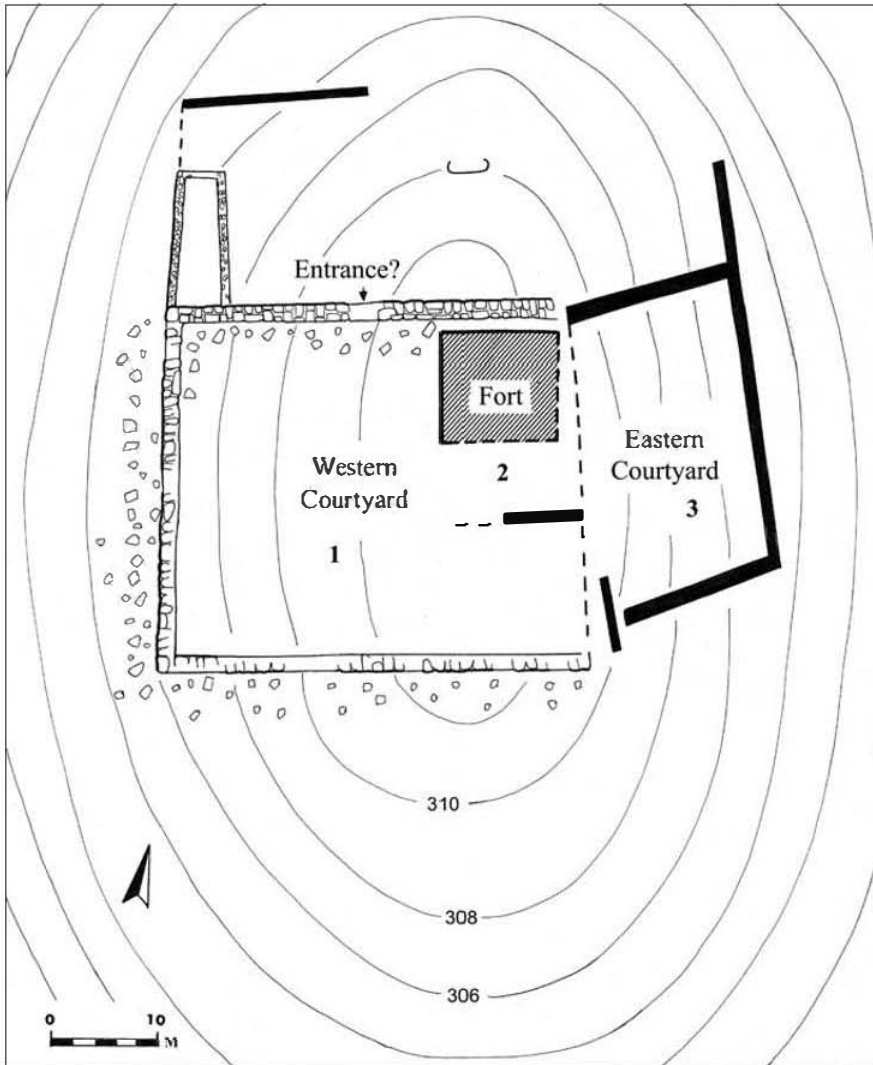
Israel grid: 1911/1699	Soil quality: 2
UTM grid: 7294/5572	Cultivation: none
Elevation: 310 m a.s.l., 50 m a.s.a.	Cisterns: none
Name: nearest place	Water source: 'Ein Abu Daraj (177), 300 m distant
Site type: fort	Road: Wadi Jaber (C39), next to the site
Area: 2 dunams (2000 sq. m)	Visits: July 1994 and many more; 51 sherds
Topography: high hilltop above a saddle	
Rock type: Avdat Group	
Soil type: desert lithosol	

A fort and courtyards on a hilltop and the saddle north of the Umm Khellal summit about 4 km north-east of Gittit. The fort is on the western slopes of the Sartaba range at the watershed between Wadi Khellal el-Fal and Wadi Jaber. There is good view to Wadi Far'ah in the east and the Gittit and Maale Ephraim areas in the west. It also dominates the 'Ein Abu Daraj spring.

There are three main parts to the fort:

1. The western courtyard: a large rectangular yard, 35×34 m, on the steep western slope of the watershed ridge. The wall is about 1.5 m thick, built of large cut stones. The northern wall and the north-western corner are well preserved, and the foundations of the other walls are also clearly visible. A narrow structure, measuring about 15×5 m, gradually narrowing towards its end, projects from the north-western corner of the courtyard. The eastern wall of the courtyard on the saddle summit no longer exists, and presumably was dismantled and the stones were taken for the construction of the eastern courtyard. A straight wall enters the western courtyard from the east, dividing it into two. There is a possible entrance in the middle of the northern wall.
2. The fort: at the hilltop summit in the north-eastern corner of the western courtyard is a square structure measuring 10×10 m. It is built of especially large well-cut stones; most of which are now in the collapse heaps. The original threshold stone and other segments of threshold and jamb stones were found in the eastern wall of this structure. Apparently the structure was a fortified tower which was the heart of the fort.
3. The eastern courtyard: in the slope east and down from the fort were found the remains of another courtyard, measuring 29×14 m, built at an obtuse angle to the north-south outer line of the western courtyard.

The north-western and south-eastern corners of this courtyard begin at the northern corner and towards the end of the dismantled eastern wall of the western courtyard. In the southern corner is an interior wall, but there is no contact with the eastern wall of the western courtyard. The construction of the eastern courtyard is different and less meticulous than that of the western yard, and perhaps it is later than the western one and the fort structure. A wall extends north from the north-eastern corner, possibly connecting in the past to a wall situated 15 m to the north of the western courtyard.



296. Plan of 'Ein Abu Daraj fort, 1994.

Three stages of construction are visible in the fort complex. According to the sherds found it is likely that it was founded in the early IA II (10th–9th centuries BCE).

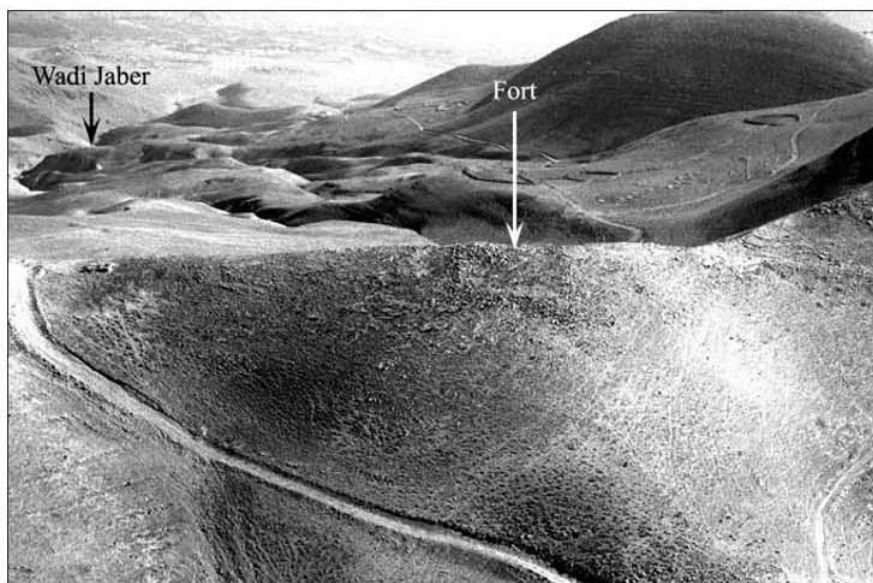
Ilan (1973: 293) described: “Above the road, north-west of Umm Khellal, are found remains of a fort built of very large cut stones (coordinates 1913/1703). Perhaps it is linked to the external defence array of the Sartaba.”

The fort of ‘Ein Abu Daraj guarded the approach to the spring and the direct road from the Jordan fords to Khirbet Tana and Shechem. The road ascended Wadi Jaber, crossing the northern Sartaba westward in the direction of Gittit.

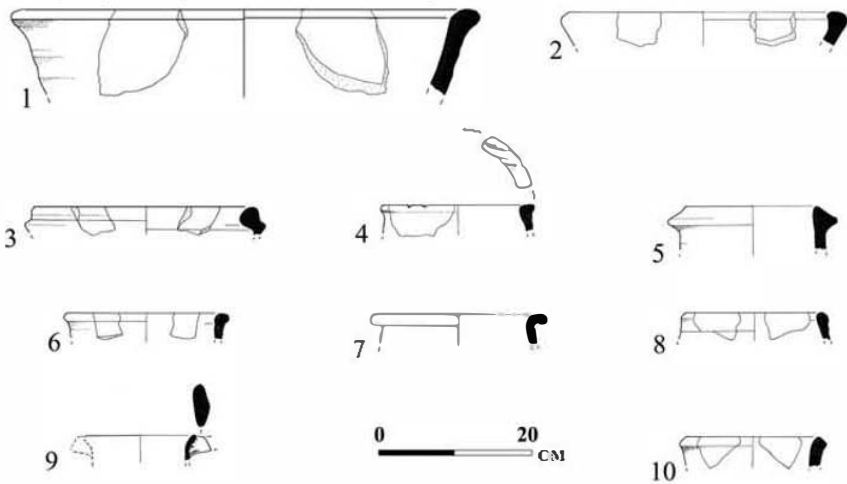
This is one of two forts guarding the approaches to the Sartaba range (together with Site 86). The complex was first built in the IA I–II, meaning that already then there was interest in the Sartaba and its environs. Another alternative is that during the IA the place was intended to guard only the spring. The fort was in service for a long time afterwards, proving the strategic importance of the place. Stylewise the fort resembles Herodian construction, but so far no sherds of that period have been found.

Pottery: Iron I – 14%; Iron II – 29%; Late Roman – 39%; Byzantine – 10%; Middle Ages – 8%.

Additional surveys: none.



297. Aerial view to the east to ‘Ein Abu Daraj fort and Wadi Jaber, 1997 (M. Einav).



298. Pottery from 'Ein Abu Daraj fort: 1. Krater, brn, Ir II; 2. Bowl, lt brn, Ir I; 3. CP, dk brn, Ir II; 4. Jug, gr, MA; 5. Jug, buff, Ir I; 6-10. Jars and jugs, brn and buff, LR.



Site 155: 19-16/19/2

THE LAHMEH COMPLEX

Israel grid: 1913/1699

UTM grid: 7299/5568

Elevation: 25● m a.s.l., 4● m b.s.a.

Name: ancient but not on map

Site type: enclosure, road and structures

Area: 5● dunams (5 ha)

Topography: slope, spurs and ravines

Rock type: Avdat Group

Soil type: alluvial brown

Soil quality: 8

Cultivation: field crops (partial)

Cisterns: none

Water source: 'Ein Abu Daraj (177), 5●● m distant

Road: Wadi Jaber (C39), next to the site

Visit: Feb. 1995; 66 sherds

A complex of sites of varied types in the upper, western, part of Wadi Jaber, about 4.5 km north-east of Gittit. Wadi Jaber drains from Ras Umm Hallal north-east into Wadi Far'ah. The Lahmeh Complex is crossed by new unpaved roads: one from the north (from the Alon road) descending eastwards along Wadi Jaber; the other ascending southwards towards the Sartaba fortress.

The complex has five parts:

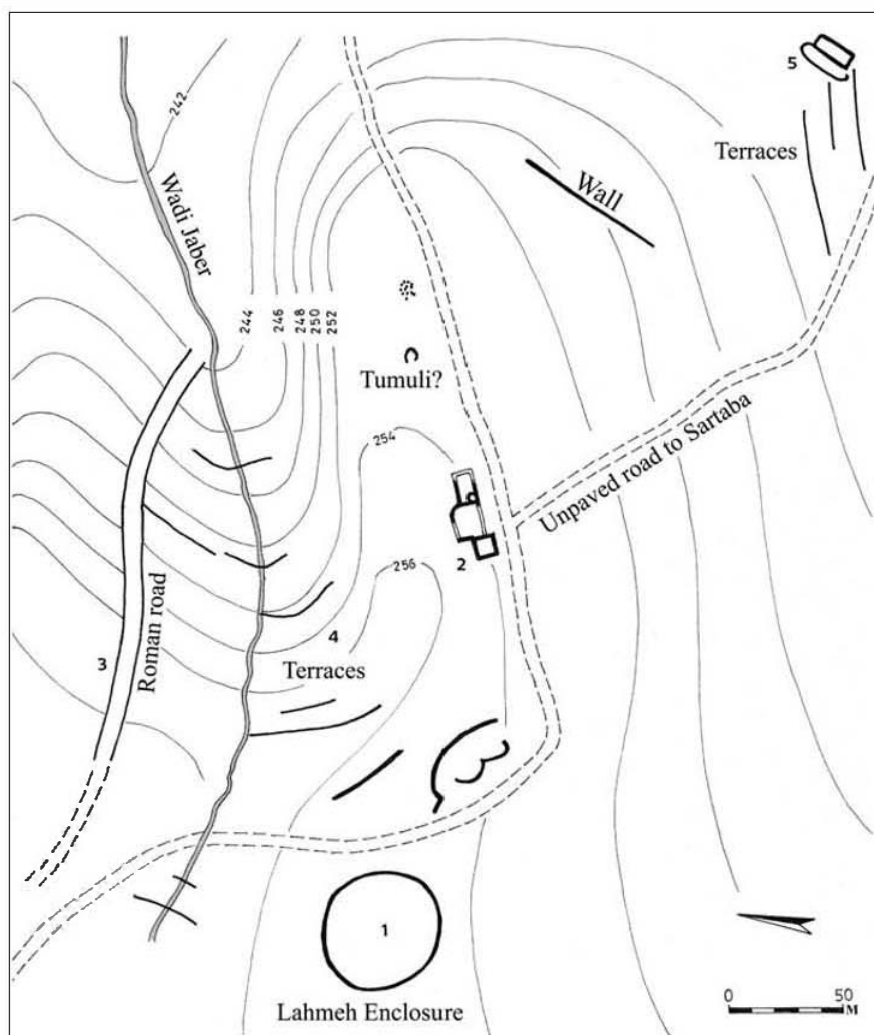
1. Sa'adat Lahmeh Enclosure: is a large round enclosure, built of stone. It is about 5● m in diameter, and the width of the enclosing wall, which

is built of large stones, is about 2 m. An unpaved road passes its eastern side.

The inside of the enclosure is divided into several courtyards by thinner walls, and is later than the construction of the original enclosure. Terrace walls project from the enclosure wall, and are prominent over the whole area and the slope west of the enclosure. Most of them are extensions of the inner courtyards in the enclosure.

A careful scrutiny in the enclosure failed to yield sherds, making it difficult to understand its dating, function and history.

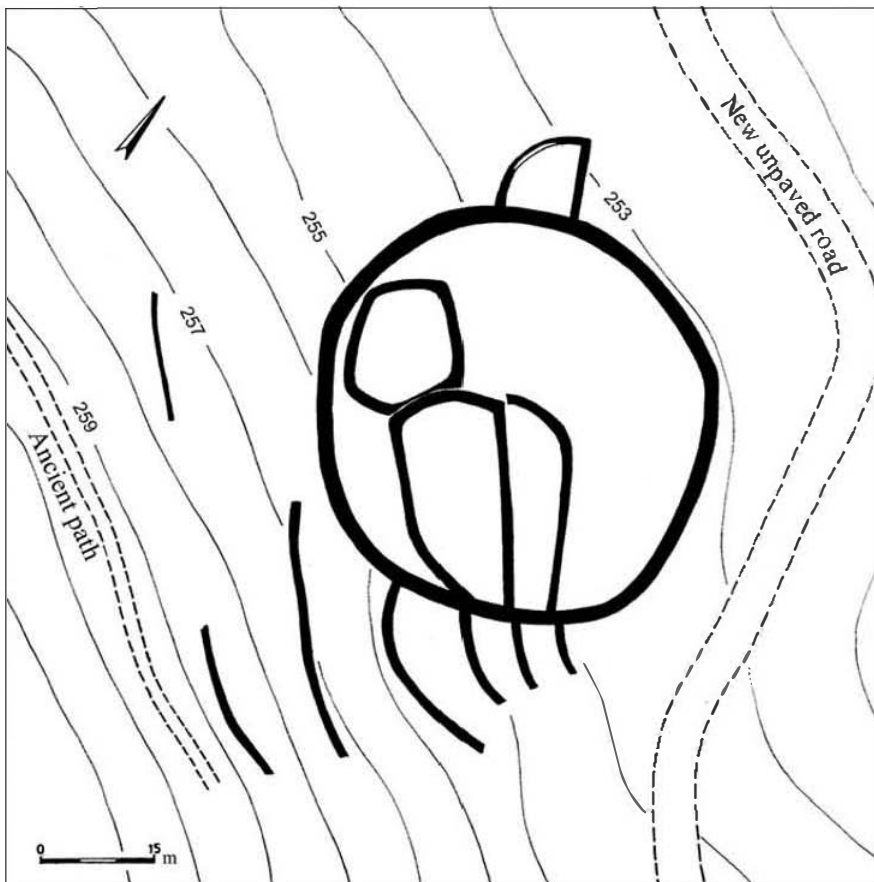
2. The courtyard and structures: about 15● m east of the enclosure are



299. Plan of the Lahmeh Complex area, 1995.

two structures, built of large cut stones, both measuring about 6×5 m. Between the structures is a courtyard, also built of large stones. About 6● m east of these structures are round stone heaps, which are perhaps remains of tumuli.

3. Over a long extension, extending more than 2●● m from the north along Wadi Jaber channel, were the remains of a built road, which has two rows of large curbstones. The road is about 6.5 m wide. These are most probably the remnants of a Roman road, one of a road system between the Jiftlik (the Jordan fords) to the east and central Samaria. This road (C39 in our nomenclature) ascends from Wadi Far'ah through the saddle of 'Ein Abu Daraj; from here it descends and meets the road ascending from Fasa'el to Neapolis-Shechem (C4●).
4. Over the whole area are many stone terraces, conforming to the terrain of the slopes, testifying to ancient agriculture.



300. Plan of the Enclosure in Lahmeh Complex, 1995.

5. About 400 m south-east of the enclosure is another stone structure and courtyard, measuring about 10×5 m, with terraces on the slope nearby.

Judging by the complexity of the site, it is probable that the place was a road junction in the IA and afterwards.

Pottery: none in the enclosure; in the rest of the site: Iron II – 5%; Late Roman – 80%; Byzantine – 15%.

Additional surveys: none.



301. Aerial view to the north of the circular enclosure at the Lahmeh Complex. The road beneath ascends to the Sartaba and Wadi Jaber, 1997 (M. Einav).

Site 156: 19-16/19/3

UMM HALLAL

Israel grid: 1915/1696

UTM grid: 7300/5564

Elevation: 408 m a.s.l., 200 m a.s.a.

Name: ancient and on map

Site type: fort (?)

Area: 1 dunam (1000 sq. m)

Topography: high summit

Rock type: Avdat Group

Soil type: desert lithosol

Soil quality: 2

Cultivation: none

Cisterns: none

Water source: 'Ein Abu Daraj (177),
600 m distant

Road: Wadi Jaber (C39), 600 m distant

Visit: May 1995; 20 sherds

A structure, maybe a fort, on Umm Hallal summit (408 m a.s.l.), one of the highest of the summits in the mountainous land block north-west of the Sartaba, about 4.5 km north-east of Gittit. There is a good view eastward to the basins of Wadi Jaber and Wadi Jeruzaliyeh, and westward to Wadi Afjeam.

The site has been badly damaged by modern constructions. Reconstruction of the remains offers the likelihood of a structure built of large stones, with estimated dimensions of 6×6 m. Around it seems to be a circular wall, forming an enclosure about 20 m in diameter. All the above were badly damaged or dismantled, and reconstruction of the original state was based on the few remains. Apparently, walls or other constructions projected from the enclosure wall. The number of sherds is particularly small.

Since the place is high and dominates the road junction below (between Wadi Jaber and Wadi Khellal el-Fal, together with the spring), it can be assumed that this was an observation post during the IA and Roman periods.

Pottery: Iron II – 80%; Early Roman – 20%.

Additional surveys: Porath 1968: site 153.

Site 157: 19-16/08/2

‘EIN ABU DARAJ (2)

Israel grid: 1907/1688

UTM grid: 7293/5557

Elevation: 160 m a.s.l., 50 m a.s.a.

Name: nearest place

Site type: sherd scatter

Area: 1 dunam (1000 sq. m)

Topography: spur

Rock type: Avdat Group

Soil type: desert lithosol

Soil quality: 4

Cultivation: none

Cisterns: none

Water source: ‘Ein Abu Daraj (177),
1 km distant

Road: Wadi Jaber (C39), 1 km distant

Visit: Feb. 1995; 46 sherds

These are scatters of sherds on a spur descending west from the Umm Hallal ridge.

The site is west of the ‘Ein abu Daraj spring. Close to the place are recent dry-built stone structures. This was probably an encampment for nomads from the IA.

Pottery: Iron II – 22%; Late Roman – 13%; Modern – 65%.

Additional surveys: none.



Site 158: 19-16/08/1

E.P. 115

Israel grid: 1901/1682

UTM grid: 7286/5550

Elevation: 70 m a.s.l., 40 m a.s.a.

Name: nearest place

Site type: structure

Area: 2 dunams (2000 sq. m)

Topography: hilltop

Rock type: Avdat Group

Soil type: brown forest

Soil quality: 6

Cultivation: none

Cisterns: none

Water source: ‘Ein Iḥafireh (174),
1.2 km distant

Road: Fasa’el-Ṭana (C40), 1 km distant

Visit: Jan. 1995; 24 sherds

A small site at the edge of a hilltop, south of E.P. 115, west of Wadi Afjeam and slightly east of the Alon road.

Remains of a square structure, measuring 5×5 m, and sherd scatter around it. Near the structure is a rock-cut cupmark 10 cm in diameter.

Pottery: Iron II – 4%; Hellenistic – 4%; Late Roman – 92%.

Additional surveys: none.

Site 159: 18-16/67/1

KH. TAWIL (1)

In the British Survey Kh. el-Tueil

Israel grid: 1868/1674

UTM grid: 7254/5542

Elevation: 330 m a.s.l., 20 m b.s.a.

Name: nearest place

Site type: structure and courtyards

Area: 12 dunams (1.2 ha)

Topography: valley margins

Rock type: Judea Group

Soil type: terra rossa

Soil quality: 6

Cultivation: none

Cisterns: 2

Water source: 'Ein el-Majdal (185),
2.4 km distantRoad: Gittit Valley (C58),
800 m distant

Visits: March 1997 and more;

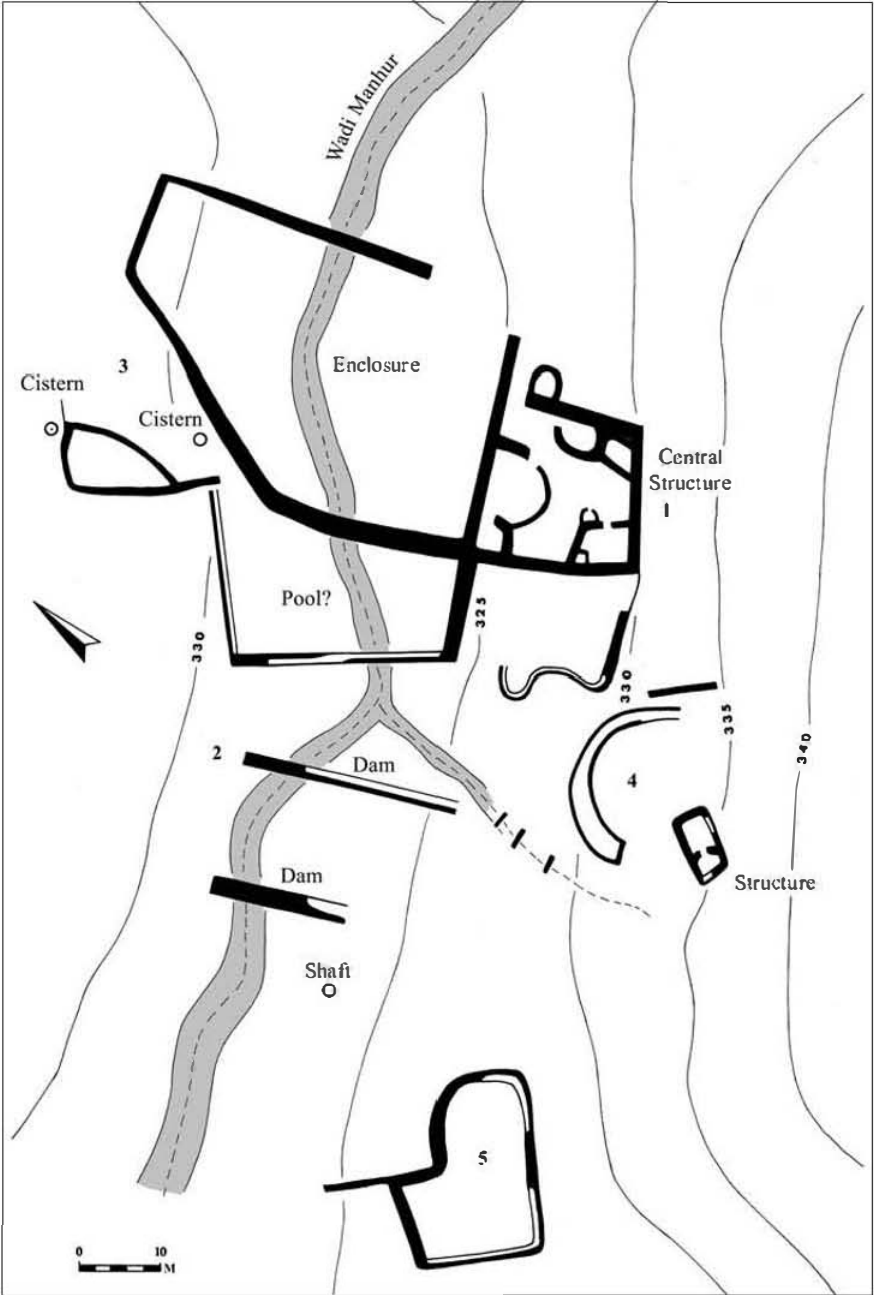
63 sherds

A complex with a large structure, courtyards, dams and installations, next to the south-western fence of Gittit, 100 m east of the Alon road, Enclosure and by a small ravine.

There are five parts to the site:

1. A central structure or courtyard: an irregular square, measuring about 20×20 m. The outside wall is 2 m thick, built of large stones, and the only entrance is from the north. Inside are at least five rooms built of small stones, abutting the encircling wall. The space inside was also used to construct rounded pens. There is an essential difference between the initial early construction of straight thick walls of large stones, and the later structures of small stones. It also clear that already at the early stage, it was partitioned into rooms also built of large stones. In the later phases, rooms were built using the framework of the ancient structure. The place appears to have been a fortified structure-courtyard serving as dwellings for a very long time.
2. Dams, courtyards and water reservoirs: in the ravine west of the central structure (the upper part of Wadi Manḥur) are four dams. Two thick walls project from the western corner of the central structure: one turns west along the wadi, curves north, crosses the wadi and turns east. Apparently this wall was a component of a water reservoir. The second wall is thicker, also starting from the western corner, and turns north-north-west. After crossing the wadi it curves north and then east and south. This long wall may have been part of another reservoir.

Up Wadi Manḥur, south-west of the central courtyard, are two more stone dams. They are about 20 m and 16 m long respectively, and both are about 2 m thick. They are apparently designed for agriculture and/or to fill cisterns.



302. Plan of Kh. Tawil (1), 1997.

In a small branch of the wadi, west of the central structure, are three more small dams.

3. Cisterns: Two rock-cut and built cisterns (in current use) in the slope west and beyond the wadi channel, about 40 m north-west of the central structure. Next to them is an irregular pen, perhaps for watering flocks.
4. Various structures and support walls south-west of the central structure, including a rectangular structure (8×4 m) built of large stones, with an inner partition apparently contemporary with the outer framework of the central structure, mounted on a wide raised semicircular platform about 30 m in diameter.
5. A large pen, about 60 m south of the central structure.

This complex was built and in use during the MBA II and IA periods. The frame structure of the central structure (1), the southern structure (4) and some of the dams belong to these periods. The place continued in use into the Persian, Roman and MA periods.

The main importance of the site is the array of dams, because the farm apparently subsisted on rainwater collected in the winter. The central structure was fortified, and its inhabitants controlled the vast surrounding agricultural areas.



303. The central structure in Kh. Tawil (1), view to the east, 2003 (M. Einav).

Remark: in the British Survey the site appears under the name Kh. Tuweil, but for unknown reasons in recent maps the name is given to the Gittit reservoir site E.P.173 (1) (Site 149). In our survey the original name has been reinstated.

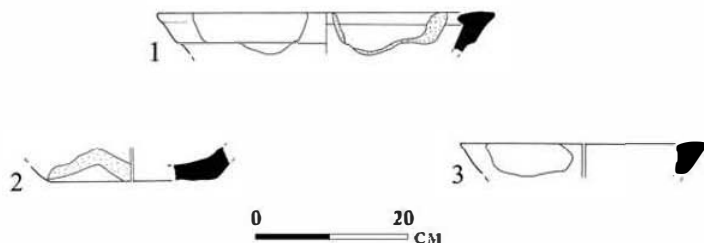
Pottery: Middle Bronze IIb – 15%; Iron I – 5%; Iron II – 31%; Late Roman – 28%; Middle Ages – 21%.

Flint: 37 items, see Appendix A.

Additional surveys: none.



304. Aerial view of Kh. Tawil (1), view to the south-east, 2013 (A. Solomon).



305. Pottery from Kh. Tawil (1), all MB II: 1, 3. Jar, buff; 2. Jug base, brn.

Site 160: 18-16/77/1

KHIRBET TAWIL (2) – EL-MINIYAH

Israel grid: 1870/1672	Soil quality: 4
UTM grid: 7256/5539	Cultivation: none
Elevation: 340 m a.s.l., 15 m a.s.a.	Cisterns: 2
Name: nearest place	Water source: 'Ein el-Majdal (185), 2.4 km distant
Site type: courtyard and structures	Road: Gittit Valley (C58), 1.2 km distant
Area: 15 dunams (1.5 ha)	Visits: March 1997, Dec. 2001;
Topography: low hill	100 sherds
Rock type: Avdat Group	
Soil type: terra rossa	

A courtyard and structures, spread on a large low hill at the eastern end of the Gittit Valley, about 500 m south-west of Gittit centre and 300 m south-east of Kh. Tawil (1).

The following structures have been found:

1. A large courtyard, measuring about 200×200 m; located on the northern slope which descends from the hill to Wadi Manḥur and is marked on the map. The courtyard construction seems to be from later times (Ottoman or modern), but integrated within it are about 20 small, single space, structures. These are built of very large stones, measuring up to 100×80 cm, and weighing up to 500 kg each. The average dimensions of the structures are 8×6 m, without openings. A few are divided into rooms.

It appears that the ancient settlement was pre-planned, and the structures are positioned in a straight line. Next to the structures were found large rock-cut basins and many cup-marks in the rocky surfaces. The linkage between the structures and the rock-cut installations is not clear.

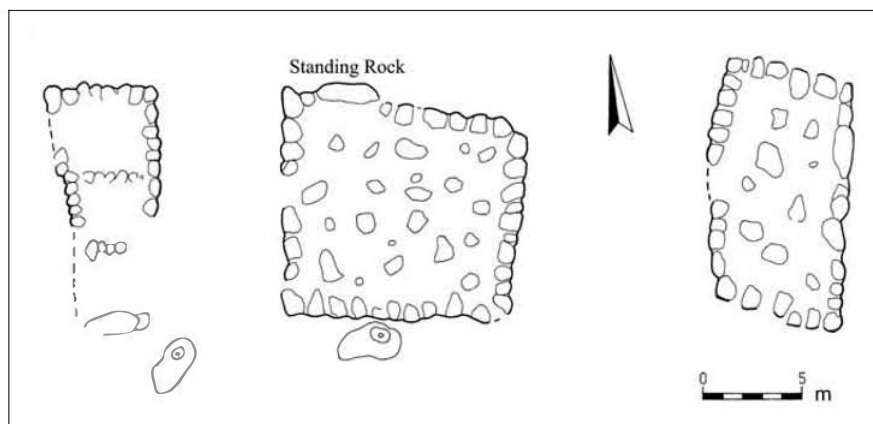
2. On the western slope of the hill are additional structures of the same design, also built of very large stones.

The hill and the long extension, extending north from E.P. 373 to Gittit, are strewn with small structures built from particularly large stones. Such a construction is unique to MBA II sites in this region, which contains scattered cell-like structures, built of very large stones.

Pottery: Middle Bronze IIb – 87%; Byzantine – 13%.

Flint: 3 items, see Appendix A.

Additional surveys: none.



306. Plan of three typical MBA II structures from Kh. Tawil (2), 2001.



Site 16● (1): 18-16/77/2

WADI EL-MANḤUR (2)

Israel grid: 1878/1671

UTM grid: 7264/5539

Elevation: 24● m a.s.l., 4● m a.s.a.

Name: nearest place

Site type: courtyard

Area: ●.5 dunam (5●● sq. m)

Topography: ravine

Rock type: Avdat Group

Soil type: terra rossa

Soil quality: 4

Cultivation: none

Cisterns: none

Water source: 'Ein es-Sukhun (175),
2.2 km distant

Road: Wadi Kamoneh-Gittit valley
(C54), 1.2 km distant

Visit: Dec. 2015; no sherds

A courtyard in a narrow ravine, north of the deep Wadi el-Manḥur, and 4●● m south-east of Gittit.

The courtyard is badly preserved. Its dimensions are 28×28 m. The walls, which are slightly less than 1 m thick, are built of medium-sized stones. The southern wall was not preserved. In the southern part is a small modern structure.

No pottery was found.

Pottery: not found.

Additional surveys: none.

Site 161: 18-16/76/1

KH. TAWIL (3)

Israel grid: 1871/1669

UTM grid: 7257/5537

Elevation: 330 m a.s.l., 30 m a.s.a.

Name: nearest place

Site type: structure

Area: 1 dunam (1000 sq. m)

Topography: slope

Rock type: Avdat Group

Soil type: terra rossa

Soil quality: 2

Cultivation: none

Cisterns: none

Water source: 'Ein es-Sukhun (175),
2.3 km distantRoad: Gittit Valley (C58), 1.3 km
distant

Visit: March 1997; 20 sherds

A large structure with rooms on the eastern slope of el-Miniyah hill, with a view to Wadi Manhūr through Wadi Afjeam.

The structure is about 20×8 m, and includes a long hall and several adjacent rooms, built of medium-sized stones. Due to erosion and considerable destruction it is difficult to discern its exact plan.

Both the layout and manner of construction are very similar to those in the MBA sites in the region. Around the structure are various walls, perhaps terraces and some rock-cut installations.

This is a typical isolated MBA farm common on the eastern slopes of Samaria.

Pottery: Middle Bronze II – 100%.

Additional surveys: none.

Site 162: 18-16/97/1

MERAH ES-SAHLAT

Israel grid: 1895/1674	Soil quality: 6
UTM grid: 7281/5542	Cultivation: none
Elevation: 90 m a.s.l., 15 m a.s.a.	Cisterns: none
Name: nearest place	Water source: 'Ein el-I-Jafireh (174), 1.7 km distant
Site type: courtyards	Road: Fasa'el–Neapolis (C41), next to the site
Area: 2 dunams (2000 sq. m)	Visits: Jan. 1995, Dec. 2001; 22 sherds
Topography: ravine	
Rock type: Avdat Group	
Soil type: terra rossa	

Two courtyards close to a small ravine on the south-western slope of E.P. 116, by the unpaved road connecting the Alon Road to the Maale Ephraim industrial zone, and 2 km east of Gittit.

The two courtyards are laid along the ravine, which descends south-east, close by the unpaved road:

1. The southern, lower, courtyard is rectangular (30×25 m), encircled by a wall 1.5–1.8 m thick built of two rows of large stones. Close by the inside of the north-western corner is a new *maq'ad*, 3 m in diameter. The courtyard was found in a much damaged state, with its south-eastern corner ruined by a bulldozer, apparently while excavating for the unpaved road.
2. The higher, northern, courtyard is about 150 m north-north-west of the southern one. It is located a little up the slope, but there is direct eye contact between the two (although it is uncertain that they existed simultaneously). The yard is rectangular, measuring 20×17 m, with an encircling wall of similar construction and thickness to the southern courtyard. The opening, 1 m wide, is near the south-western corner, and is marked by two standing monoliths. Several terrace walls project an average of 15 m from the south-western wall of the courtyard in a south-westerly direction. Apparently their function was to support the courtyard infrastructure.

Outside the south-eastern wall of the courtyard, and close to it, is a unique structure (A). It is oval (2.5×1.5 m), and is encircled by a wall of medium- and large-sized stones. The inside is paved with large flat stones. A similar structure is found inside the north-western corner of the courtyard. The functions and dating of these structures are unclear; possibly they served for storage of agricultural produce requiring a floor.

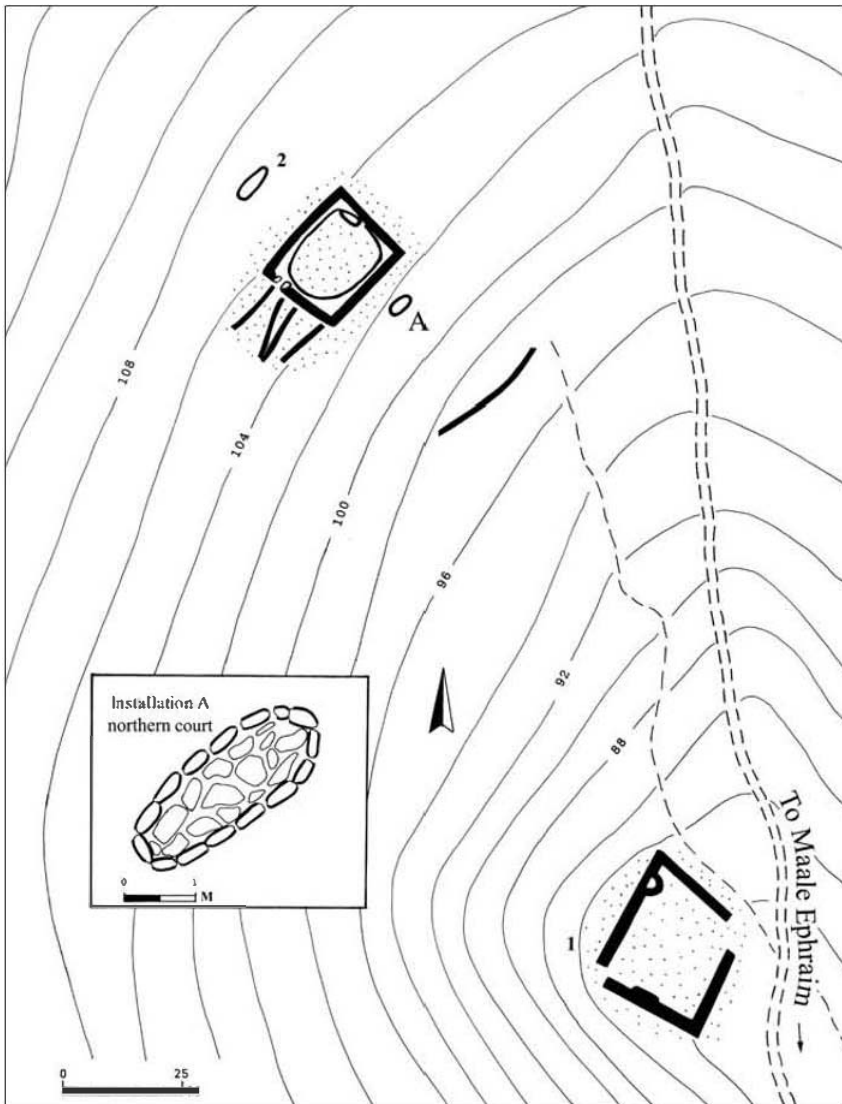
There are many sherds in the upper courtyard and few in the lower one.

The square courtyards were built during the LR-Byz periods, but all of them have IA infrastructure. Possibly, already then they were livestock pens or sites of another nature.

Pottery: Iron II – 16%; Late Roman-Byzantine – 66%; Middle Ages – 6%; Ottoman – 12%.

Flint: 6 items, see Appendix A.

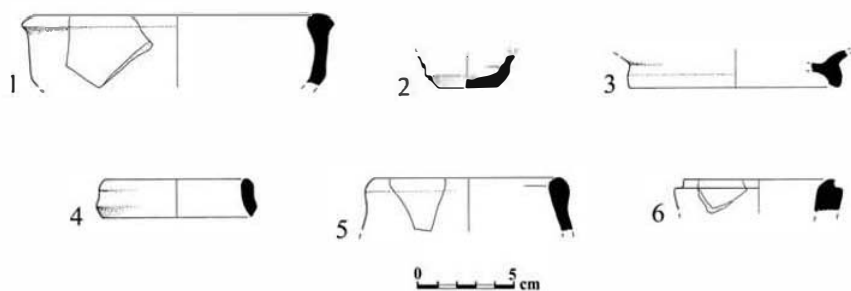
Additional surveys: none.



307. Plan of Merah es-Sahlat, 2001.



308. The upper (northern) courtyard at Merah es-Sahlat, view to the north-west, 2001 (M. Einav).



309. Pottery from Merah es-Sahlat: 1. Bowl, buff, Ir II; 2. Juglet base, brn, Byz; 3. Bowl base, pk, LR; 4. Jug, brn; 5. Jar, lt brn, Ir II; 6. Jar, brn, Ir II.

Site 163: 19-16/●7/1

ABU FARO

Israel grid: 19●●/1676

UTM grid: 7286/5544

Elevation: 9● m a.s.l., 4● m a.s.a.

Name: ancient but not on map

Site type: farm

Area: 2 dunams (2●●● sq. m)

Topography: saddle

Rock type: Avdat Group

Soil type: brown forest

Soil quality: 5

Cultivation: none

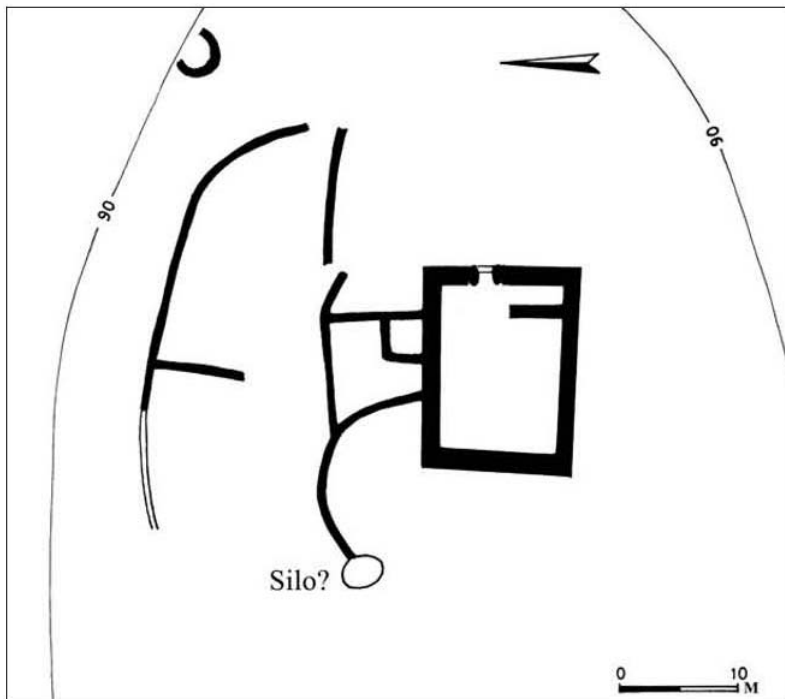
Cisterns: none

Water source: 'Ein el-Hafreh (174),
1.2 km distantRoad: Fasa'el-Neapolis (C41),
next to the site

Visit: Jan. 1995; 68 sherds

A site on a saddle, part of a spur (E.P. 116) overlooking Wadi Afjeam from the north, about 6●● m east of the Alon road, and about 2.5 km east of Gittit.

In the centre of the site is a rectangular courtyard, measuring 18×13 m. The wall is 1.5 m thick, built of two rows of slightly worked stones. Two standing jamb stones mark the opening in the short eastern wall, and an indication



310. Plan of Abu Faro, 1995.

of a later bolt. Towards the eastern wall, is a wall about 5 m long, apparently preceding the construction of the courtyard.

About 10 m north of the courtyard is a badly built parallel wall, with two walls meeting the northern wall, forming an enclosed space. In it is another smaller space, adjacent to the courtyard wall and the eastern wall going north. One of the perpendicular walls (the northern one) curves to end in a round silo, 3 m in diameter. North of the complex is another curved wall, about 40 m long, perhaps serving originally as the enclosure wall.

The first phase of the construction was apparently a round enclosure, with subsidiary constructions, on top of which the rectangular courtyard was built. The first phase was probably built when the site was established – IA II. The IA stones were re-used to build the later rectangular courtyard.

The farm is a good example of a typical development in this region: an IA farm, whose stones were re-used to build a Roman site. In this case there is also a Hellenistic phase.

Pottery: Iron II – 24%; Hellenistic – 21%; Late Roman – 38%; Byzantine – 13%; Modern – 4%.

Additional surveys: none.



Site 164: 19-16/27/1

RAS QUNEITRA

Israel grid: 1928/1673

UTM grid: 7314/5542

Elevation: 300 m a.s.l., 0 m a.s.a.

Name: ancient and on map

Site type: encampment, tumuli and prehistoric

Area: 5 dunams (5000 sq. m)

Topography: plateau

Rock type: Avdat Group

Soil type: brown forest

Soil quality: 4

Cultivation: none

Cisterns: none

Water source: 'Ein el-Hafireh (174), 1.7 km distant

Road: Wadi Jeruzaliyeh (C43), next to the site

Visit: April 1996; 56 sherds

An encampment, tumulus field and prehistoric site on the heights of the Sartaba massif, about 2 km north-west of the Sartaba fortress. Close by to the south passes the unpaved road to the Sartaba.

A concentration of 12 structures, of which only the foundations survive, on a flat broad saddle measuring about 100×100 m. Most of the structures are

round, and some are slightly oval, averaging 4 m across, except for two which are 7 m across. The construction is of medium-sized stones. Most of the structures were found robbed and empty.

In the north-eastern part of the site is a rectangular structure, built of large stones, measuring 5×2 m.

It can be assumed that these structures are tumuli of unknown date, which were dismantled or robbed in later periods (modern?). From the Hellenistic period until today the saddle has served intensively as encampment site. The number of sherds is relatively large, indicating prolonged use.

Pottery: Chalcolithic (?) – 2.5%; Hellenistic – 7%; Roman – 21%; Byzantine – 3.5%; Early Moslem – 7%; Middle Ages – 31%; Ottoman – 14%; Modern – 14%.

Flint: 94 items, Middle Palaeolithic, see Appendix A.

Additional surveys: none.



Site 165:

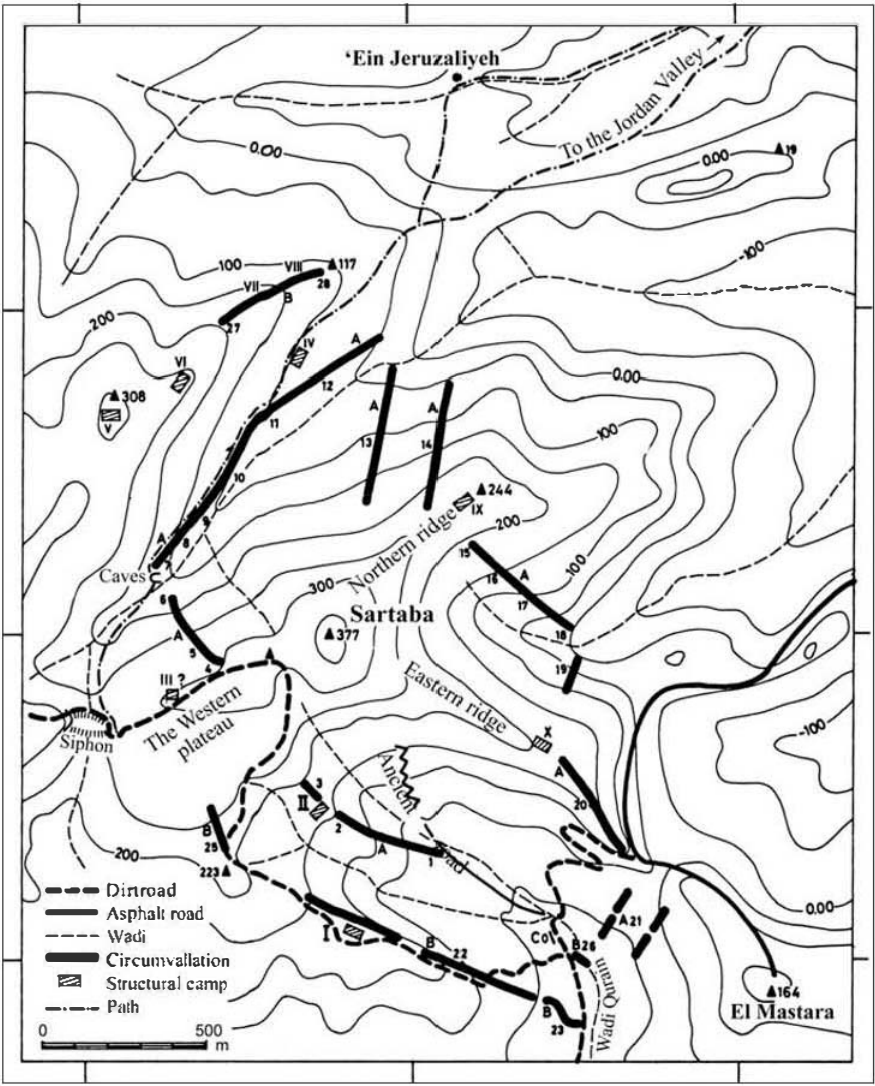
SARTABA SIEGE WORKS

This is a brief description of many sections of a siege wall (circumvallation) and possible camps, linked to the two systems of siege works of the Sartaba Cone. The siege works were investigated by Ze'ev Meshel in the early 1970s (Meshel 1984). It contains the following parts:

1. The circumvallation: Meshel proposes two walls – inner and outer, which differ in thickness: the inner wall is up to 1 m thicker than the outer one. Both walls encircle the Sartaba fortress, but not completely: the outer one is 500–600 m from the fortress, and the other one about 100 m closer in. Only sections remain from both walls, which can be virtually connected via several different routes. Two new plans of different parts of the walls were prepared by the survey team and are presented below (the Wadi Mastara area and the southern ascent to the fortress).
2. Camps and enclosures: Meshel traced remains of many enclosures, towers and 'camps' surrounding the Sartaba fortress on all sides. Following is Meshel's list:
 - An enclosure (I) – 24×10 m, built at the edge of the cliff south-east of the citadel;
 - A 'doubtful enclosure' (II);
 - An animal pen at 'Ein Jeruzaliyeh (IV);
 - A fort in E.P. 308 – rectangular structure – 19×15 m, wall thickness 1.5

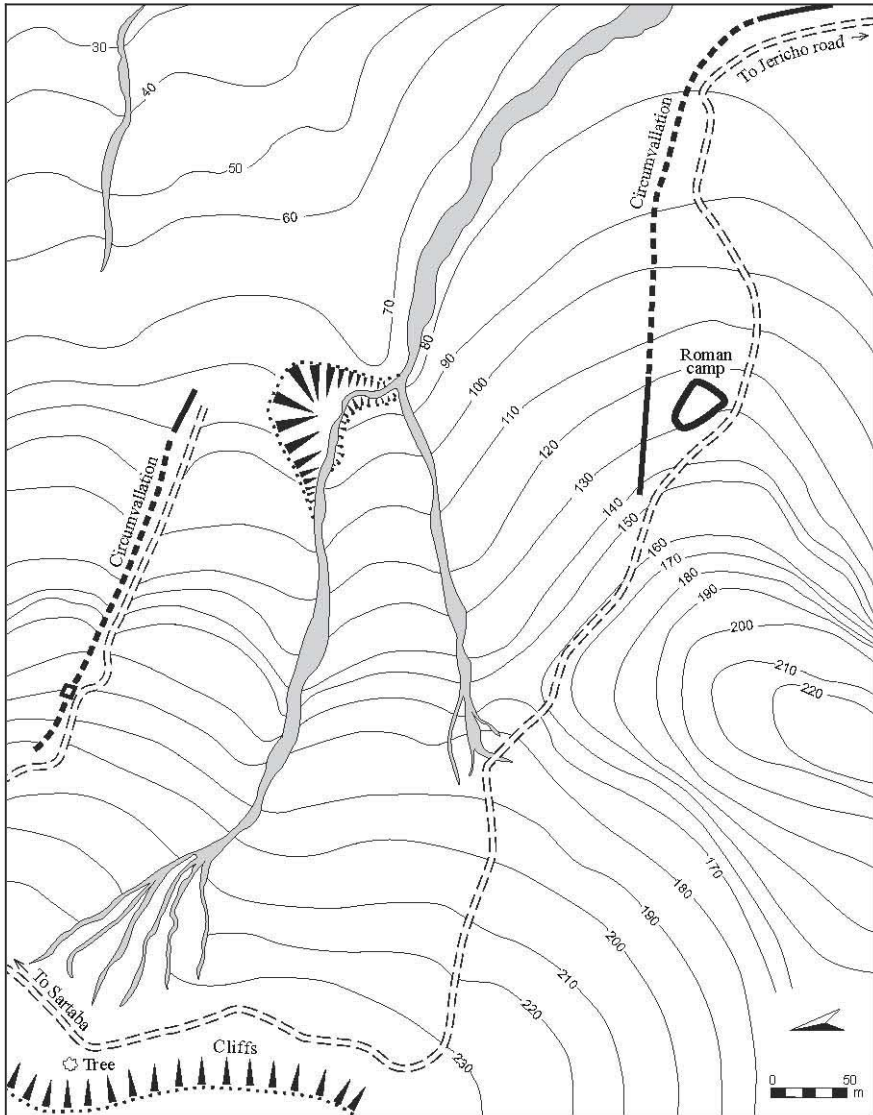
- m (V);
- A collapse heap on a hilltop (VI);
- A structure adjacent to the wall (VII) – 11x10 m;
- A small tower attached to the wall (VIII);
- The northern spur (IX);
- A 'doubtful camp' on the eastern spur (X).

The siege works raise many problems. In Meshel's opinion, they were never completed. It is unclear why two walls were built, and if both walls



311. Plan of the Sartaba Siege System (Meshel 1989: fig. 1).

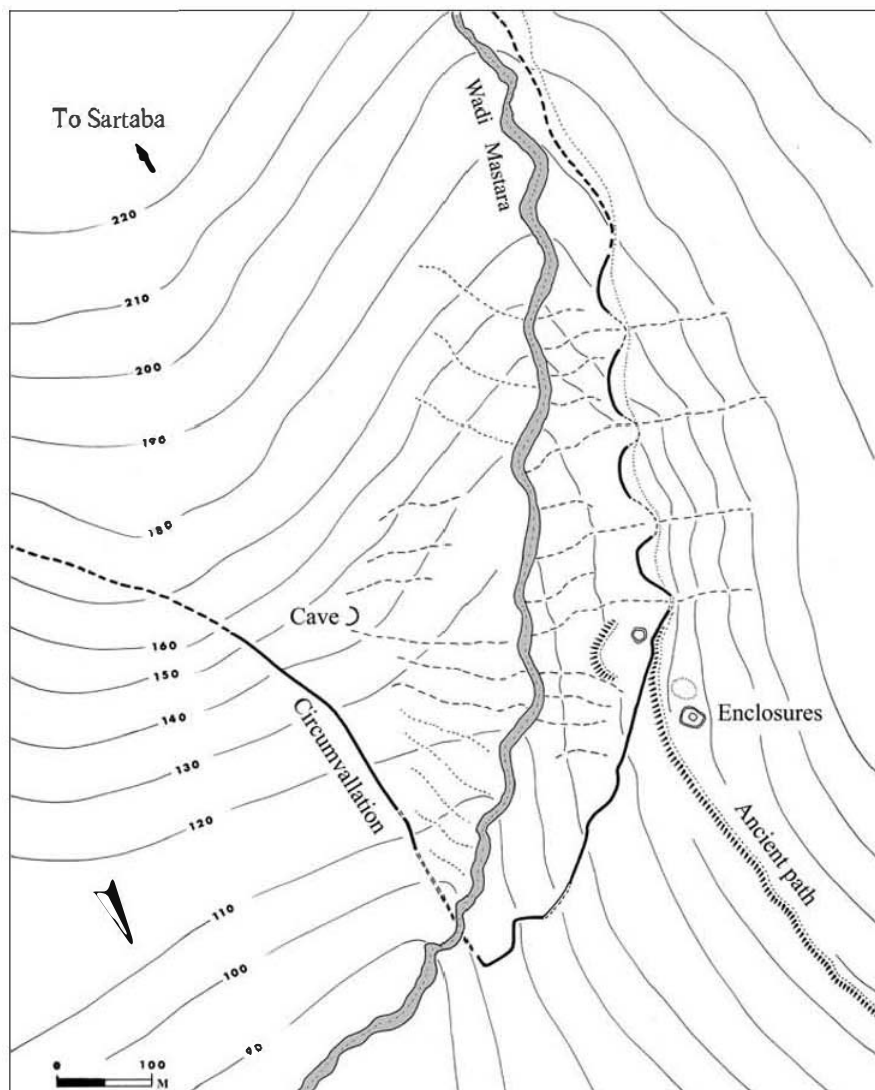
belong to one single siege work system. If they are from different periods, there must have been a reason why the later builders did not use the earlier one. The lack of a siege ramp suggests that the fortress was already taken, if indeed it was, but not by assault. Historically, Meshel relates both siege systems to the time of the Roman commander Gabinus (Josephus, War, I, VIII, 3-5; Antiquities, XIV, V, 2-4-57 BCE): the first system was built by Gabinus when he besieged Alexandrion and then left an army there;



312. Plan of a section of the Sartaba Siege System at the southern ascent to the fortress, 2010.

and the second one was built after Gabinius' return from his campaign in Judea, which was intended to establish order there.

3. Sections of the siege works at present: only some parts of the siege works published by Meshel have been re-examined by the Manasseh Hill Country Survey. At coordinates 1938/1684, next to the ancient path ascending from Wadi Jeruzaliyeh – we drew part of the outer wall. This wall was 1 m wide, built of small stones, and large sections of it were eroded



313. Plan of a section of the Sartaba Siege System at the meeting points with Wadi Mastara and with the ancient path ascending from Wadi Jeruzaliyeh, 1999.

completely away. It descends a steep slope from the eastern side of the Sartaba fortress to Wadi Mastara, where it crosses Wadi Mastara and turns sharply south-west. From here the wall (which at this point is well preserved) ascends along the ancient path. The topographical rationale for its location is not clear. Another section drawn by our team is the area of the southern ascent to the site. Here the remains of a small Roman camp and two partly preserved sections of the wall are visible.

No sherds or other means of dating were found along the circumvallation wall.

Additional Bibliography: Meshel 1989.



314. View to the west at a section of the north-eastern circumvallation wall of the Sartaba Siege System, 1996 (M. Einav).

Site 166: 18-16/76/1

WADI EL-MANḤUR (1)

Israel grid: 1873/1667

UTM grid: 7259/5534

Elevation: 28● m a.s.l., 3● m b.s.a.

Name: nearest place

Site type: courtyard

Area: 1 dunam (1●●● sq. m)

Topography: flat shoulder

Rock type: Avdat Group

Soil type: terra rossa

Soil quality: 6

Cultivation: none

Cisterns: none

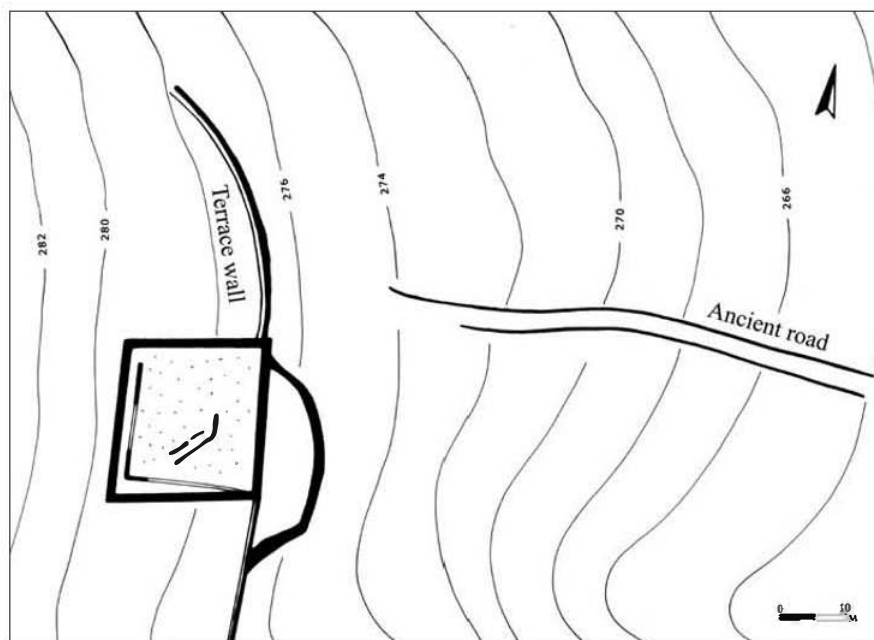
Water source: 'Ein es-Sukhun (175),
2 km distantRoad: Wadi Kamoneh-Gittit valley
(C54), 1.6 km distant

Visit: Feb. 1997; 62 sherds

A courtyard on a broad shoulder, east of the el-Miniyah hilltop, 1 km south of Gittit.

The dimensions of the courtyard are 23×23 m. The walls, which are about 1 m thick, are built of two parallel rows of large stones. Along the inside of the walls is a more ancient construction phase in a different orientation.

The courtyard rests on a thick north-south support wall 7● m long at the bottom of the slope. A curved wall, the diameter of which is greater than that



315. Plan of Wadi el-Manḥur (1), 1997.

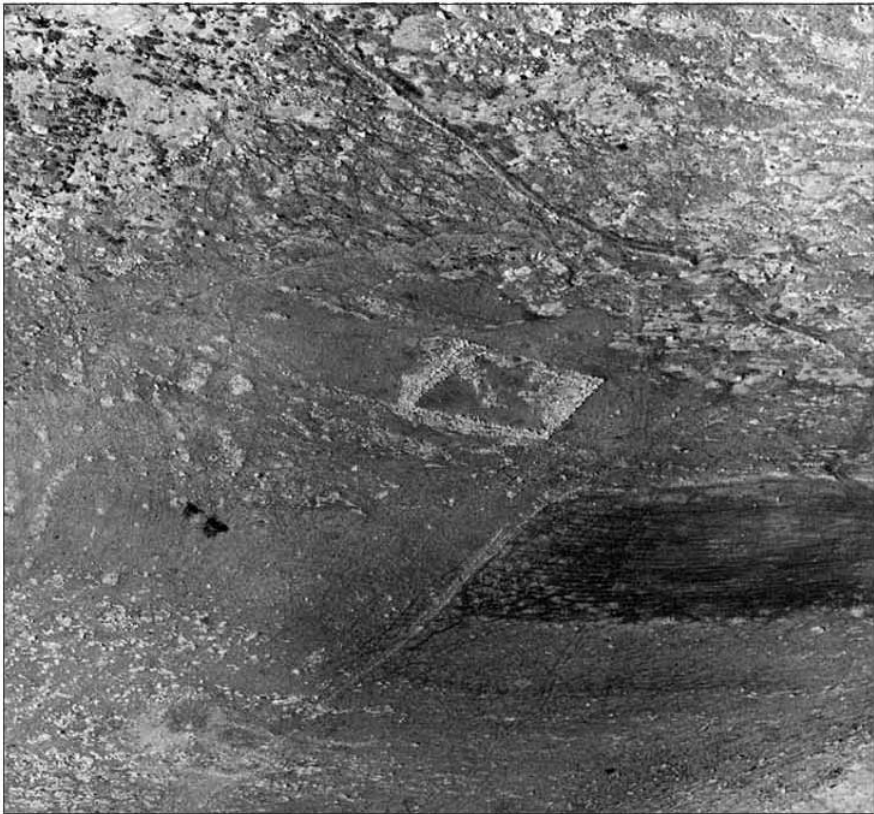
of the yard, projects eastward from the support wall. This wall may be part of the ancient IA enclosure, or even an earlier one (MBA?). The lack of IA II sherds here is significant.

A constructed road begins some distance from the courtyard, running eastward. It is about 3 m wide and about 2 km long. It most probably precedes the building of the courtyard, because it does not relate to it (but rather to the support wall), and there is an obvious gap between the yard and the beginning of the road. If this is the case, the road went out of use before the courtyard was built. Apparently, this was a local road or a branch of the Fasa'el–Neapolis road (C4●). In the 1:50,000 scale maps this road is marked as a path.

East of the courtyard are agricultural terraces, and on the hill south-east of the site are various rock-cut installations.

Pottery: Middle Bronze IIb – 10%; Iron I – 48%; Persian-Hellenistic – 8%; Roman – 26%; Middle Ages – 8%.

Additional surveys: none.



316. Aerial view to the west of Wadi el-Manḥūr (1), 2013 (A. Solomon).

Site 167: 18-16/96/1

MRAḤ ES-SAHLEH

Israel grid: 1891/1667

UTM grid: 7277/5535

Elevation: 5● m a.s.l., 2● m b.s.a.

Name: nearest place

Site type: courtyard and installations

Area: 5 dunams (5●●● sq. m)

Topography: valley margins

Rock type: Judea Group

Soil type: terra rossa

Soil quality: 5

Cultivation: none

Cisterns: none

Water source: 'Ein es-Sukhun (175),
1.6 km distant

Road: Fasa'el-Ṭana (C4●), 1 km distant

Visit: Feb. 1997; 71 sherds

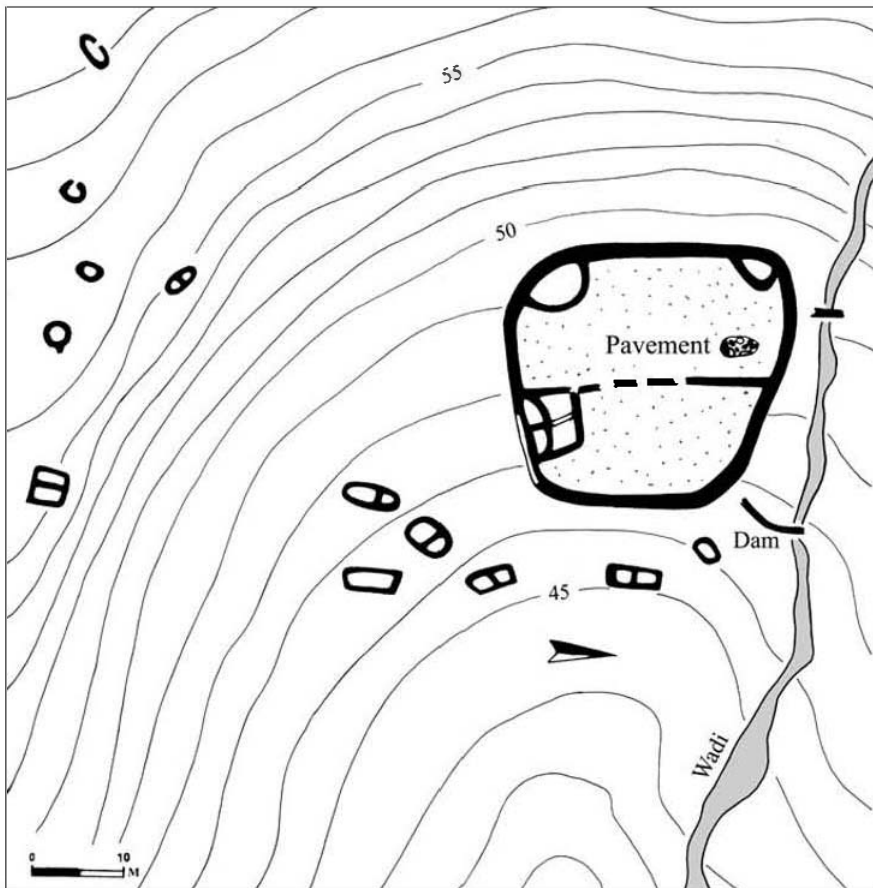
A courtyard and installations at the edge of a small valley, a part of the drainage basin of Wadi Afjeam in the area of Mraḥ es-Sahleh, 1.7 km south-east of Gittit. The location is in the hilly area between Mekhora-Maale Ephraim and the unpaved road leading south to the Maale Ephraim industrial zone.

The site has two main parts:



317. Aerial view to the west of the courtyard and installations at Mraḥ es-Sahleh, 1997 (M. Einav).

1. An irregular courtyard, measuring about 30×25 m. Two construction phases are distinguishable: an earlier one built of large stones, and above it a later one built of small stones. The later walls are mostly, but not all, built on the lines of the earlier walls. The courtyard is bisected by a wall, apparently from the earlier phase. Inside and adjacent to the courtyard walls are several small irregularly shaped structures; possibly from the later phase.
2. South and east of the courtyard, and 20 to 50 m from it, are 12 small stone-built structures. Most of them are round or oval, ranging from 2 to 5 m across. Some of these structures have a dividing wall inside, creating two rooms. Apparently the structures served as grain silos. The small structures can be distinguished as two obvious groups: six of them, the larger ones, are very close east of the courtyard; the other six, mostly the smaller ones, are grouped up the slope, about 50 m south of the courtyard.



318. Plan of Mrah es-Sahleh. 1997.

Construction-wise, all the structures belong to the later phase: however, pottery from all the periods was gathered nearby.

In the small ravine close by, to the north of the site, were two dams; and there were remains of agricultural activity all over that area.

Apparently, the place was a farm in the IA, and the later structures were built on its remains. The grain silos (?) are a phenomenon unique to this place, although such installations (with paving) are also found in Site 162.

Pottery: Iron II – 18%; Byzantine – 56%; Middle Ages – 26%.

Additional surveys: none.



Site 168: 19-16/06/1

E.P. 105

Israel grid: 1906/1664

UTM grid: 7292/5533

Elevation: 100 m a.s.l., 50 m a.s.a.

Name: nearest place

Site type: courtyards

Area: 10 dunams (1 ha)

Topography: hilltop

Rock type: Judea Group

Soil type: terra rossa

Soil quality: 4

Cultivation: none

Cisterns: none

Water source: 'Ein el-Mana (176),
800 m distant

Road: Fasa'el-Ṭana (C40),
next to the site

Visit: Nov. 1995; 75 sherds

Two courtyards on the broad hilltop of E.P.105, about 3.5 km east-southeast of Gittit. A constructed Roman road, a branch of the Fasa'el-Neapolis road, ascends to the site on an elongated spur. This road (Site 177) probably reached the Alexandrion fortress, but there is no proof of this. There is a fine view westward to Wadi Afjeam, Gittit and Maale Ephraim.

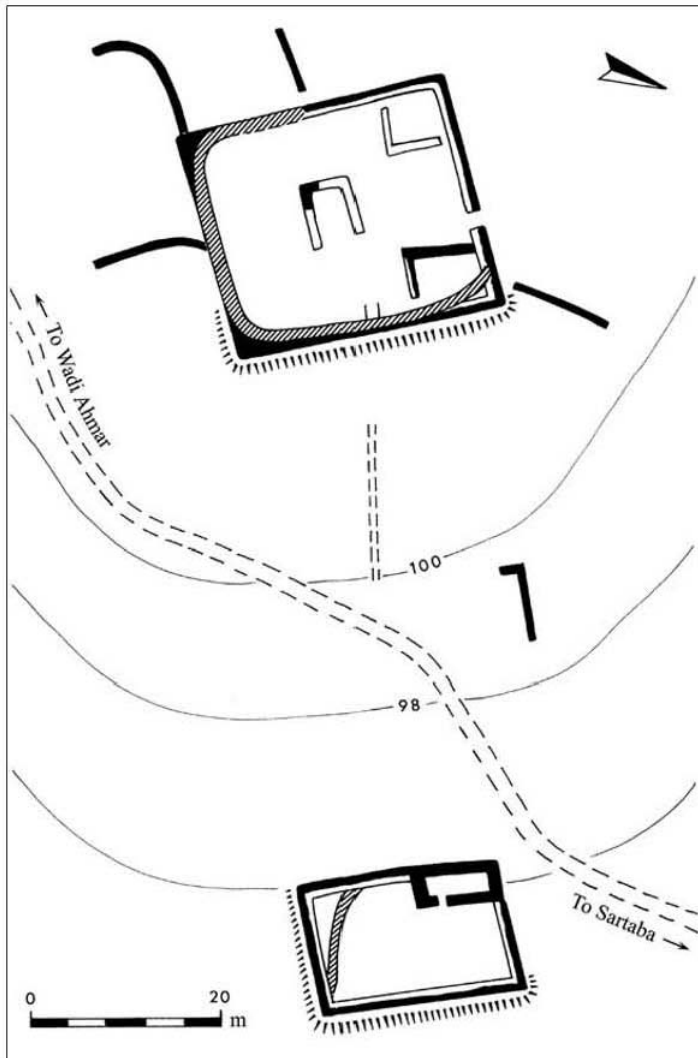
The site is positioned at the junction of new unpaved roads. A road descending from the Sartaba from the north-east splits into two branches here: one southward down to Wadi Ahmar, and the other westward to the Maale Ephraim industrial zone.

The site includes two large stone-built courtyards and additional remains. Three main phases are distinguishable:

1. During the ER Period (Herodian?) several structures were built. After the destruction of these structures the stones were used for the construction

of the later phases. Possibly in this period there was a farm or guardpost at the site, connected to the Roman road to the Sartaba.

2. In the LR Period, (1st–3rd centuries CE) the two square courtyards, now the most significant remains in the site, were built. They continued to function in the Byz period. Their description is as follows:
 - The smaller eastern courtyard measures about 20×15 m, with a wall built of large cut stones.
 - The larger western courtyard is 55 m west of the other, and measures



319. Plan of E.P.105, 1995. The earlier construction phase (Rom-Byz) is in black, and the MA annexes are hatched.

about 30×25 m, and is also built of large cut stones. It is in a poor state of preservation. It is assumed that there was an opening on the northern side. Inside the courtyard are various structures which are difficult to associate with any of the phases.

3. In the third phase (MA?), a structure measuring about 10×5 m, with thick walls, was built in the north-western corner of the eastern courtyard. At this stage a secondary construction of small stones (hatched in the plan) appears in the courtyards, apparently to divide the yards into animal pens.

The abundance of sherds and the construction phases testify to a permanent settlement, rather than an encampment site. Apparently there was a linkage between the site and the defence system of Alexandrion fortress, at least during the ER Period. Later, when the fortress ceased functioning, the place became a settlement. The spring at 'Ein el-Mana supplied water. The site should perhaps be linked to the two other forts (Rujm es-Si'a – Site 86 and 'Ein Abu Daraj Fort – Site 154) which guarded the ascending approaches to the fortress of Alexandrion.

Despite a very thorough search we failed to find the rest of the Roman road to Alexandrion.

Pottery: Iron II – 2%; Early Roman – 15%; Late Roman – 45%; Byzantine – 20%; Middle Ages – 18%.

Additional surveys: none.



320. Aerial view to the west of E.P. 105, 2013 (A. Solomon).



321. The eastern structure at E.P. 105, view to the west, 1995.



Site 169: 19-16/16/1

‘EIN EL-MANA

Israel grid: 1914/166●

UTM grid: 73●●/5529

Elevation: 5 m a.s.l., 1●● m a.s.a.

Name: ancient but not on map

Site type: spring with structures
and prehistoric site

Area: 5 dunams (5●●● sq. m)

Topography: slope

Rock type: Judea Group

Soil type: marl

Soil quality: 3

Cultivation: none

Cisterns: none

Water source: ‘Ein el-Mana (176),
at the site

Road: Fasa’el-Ṭana (branch of C4●),
3●● m distant

Visit: Jan. 1996; 25 sherds

A site on a high slope above the spring in a wadi bed, about 2.5 km south-south-west of the Sartaba cone. Close to the site to the west is the unpaved road which ascends to the Sartaba from the south.

A paved path leaves the unpaved road, passing by the spring and continuing down to the valley of Wadi Ahmar. This path, nowadays in continuous use, passes the foot of the site without relating to it at all.

The site is located on a platform at the foot of the spring. In the bottom part of the platform is a wall, apparently intended for rainwater drainage. Next to and nearby were traced more construction remains, whose nature we could

not determine. Pottery and flint items were gathered in this area, but the overall nature of the site is not clear.

The relation between the spring and the site is unknown. It should be underlined that the spring does not appear in the maps at the correct location: in the 1:50,000 map the spring is mistakenly located in Wadi Ahmar near E.P -35 and Site 196, 2 km south-east of its actual location. At the emergence of the spring is a modern concrete water collection reservoir for watering flocks.

The place may not have been a constructed site, but rather a hub for the spring water supply.

Pottery: Iron II – 12%; Early Roman – 28%; Late Roman – 60%.

Flint: 98 items, Middle Palaeolithic, see Appendix A.

Additional surveys: none.



322. The spring and pool at 'Ein el-Mana, 1996 (M. Einav).

Site 170: 19-16/26/1

E.P. 278

Israel grid: 1926/1667	Soil quality: 3
UTM grid: 7313/5535	Cultivation: none
Elevation: 278 m a.s.l., 100 m a.s.a.	Cisterns: none
Name: nearest place	Water source: 'Ein el-Mana (176),
Site type: prehistoric and installations	1.4 km distant
Area: 1 dunam (1000 sq. m)	Road: Wadi Jeruzaliyeh (C43),
Topography: flat spur	200 m distant
Rock type: Judea Group	Visit: April 1996
Soil type: stony-desert	

A prehistoric site over a broad spur, sloping down south-west to the Sartaba. The location is south-west of the Sartaba's water system siphon, not far from the path which ascends to it from the south.

In the north-western part of the site is a considerable scatter of flint items. On the western edge are rocky surfaces with rock-cut installations, which are also found in the centre of the spur. About 15 installations were found, mostly basins, of various depths, with diameters up to 20 cm. Channels were cut in some of the surfaces.

At the south-western end of the spur is a hewn monolith about 1.5 m high and 60 cm wide. On the spur is a recent encampment site and several Bedouin graves.

Flint: Middle Palaeolithic.

Additional Surveys: none.

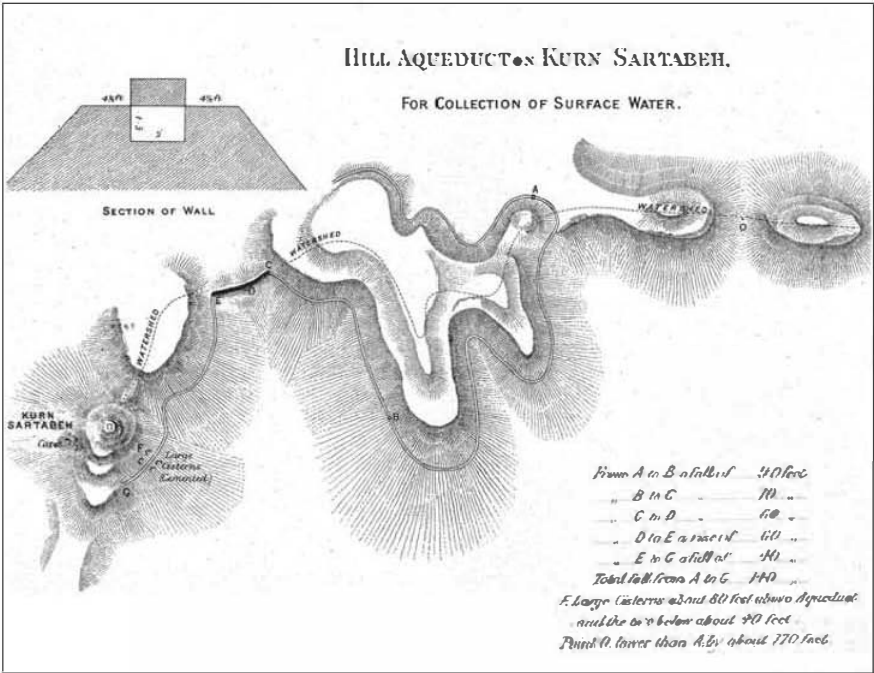
Site 171: 19-16/36/1

THE SARTABA WATER SYSTEM

Israel grid: 193/166 (central)	Soil type: stony-desert
UTM grid: 731/553 (central)	Soil quality: 3
Elevation: about 300 m a.s.l., (average)	Cultivation: none
Name: functional	Cisterns: those of the Sartaba fortress
Site type: water collecting system	Water source: at the site
Area: about 700 dunams (70 ha) – drainage basin	Road: Wadi Jeruzaliyeh (C43), near by the system
Topography: mountainous plateau	Visits: 1996. 2001 and many repeated visits; 150 sherds
Rock type: Avdat Group	

A sophisticated system for catching and collecting rain water, spread over large area west of the Sartaba fortress. The system includes aqueducts at various elevations, a siphon across a low valley, and cisterns.

The system was first investigated by the British Survey (March and April 1874) with elevations, calculations and a drawing: “On the ridge west of the tell



323. Plan of the Sartaba water system as measured and drawn by the British Survey in 1874 (Conder and Kitchener 1882: facing p. 397).

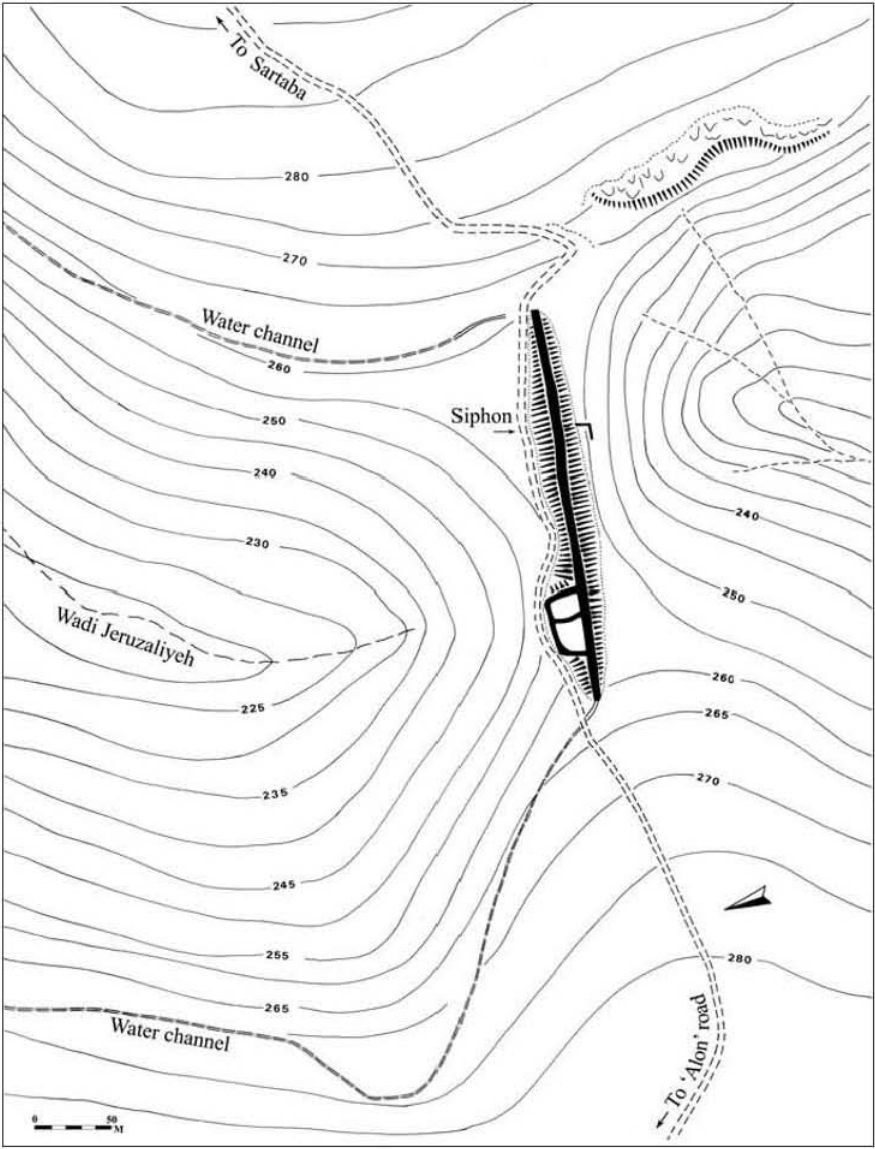
there is a well. About half mile further west there is a low saddle, which has been artificially banked across; and a long narrow wall runs on the bank, with remains of a channel 1 foot 3 inches deep and 2 feet wide with covering blocks of stones, which were probably 8 or 10 feet long. This aqueduct was traced all round the north side of the Kurn block of hill, and evidently collected surface drainage, as the level prevents the supposition of its connection with any neighbouring spring or well of water.

The total length is about 2.5 miles, but the starting-point is only $\frac{3}{4}$ mile



324. Plan of the Sartaba water system, published by Amit, 1984.

west of the tell. The watershed north of Ras Kaneitrah is 17● feet lower than the aqueduct on that side, and the line is plainly seen running round the hill, with a fall of 1●● feet in about 1.5 miles, measuring to the bank across the saddle, where the channel dips in crossing, the centre being about 5● or 6● feet lower than the ends. From the saddle the line runs directly east on the north side of the hill, with a fall of 4● feet in a mile. It supplies large cemented cave-



325. Plan of a part of the lower aqueduct and the Hellenistic siphon of the Sartaba water system, 2001.

cisterns about 35● feet or more below the top of the tell, and it runs past them to terraces which seem artificial, and many have supported gardens irrigated by the channel. In places the channel is built of large rudely hewn blocks. The well or cistern mentioned above, on the plateau west of the tell, may perhaps have been connected with the aqueduct, being at rather higher level." (Conder and Kitchen 1882: 397-398).

The water system was also investigated by David Amit (1984).

In June 2001 we drew the siphon which transfers the water from west to east across the saddle between the drainage systems of Wadi Jeruzaliyah (north) and Wadi 'Amrah (south). The length of the siphon is about 25● m. It includes a built channel, measuring 6●×6● cm, covered by stone slabs. The beginning section of the channel in the western side was fully exposed. The width of the built base on and within which the aqueduct passes is about 2 m. This base is built as a platform of cut stones in several distinct phases, perhaps repairs. There may have been several channels, but this cannot be proven without excavation.

The stone base and duct rest on an elevated foundation, whose maximum width at the bottom is about 4● m. The foundation was built of stones collected in the vicinity, and its maximum height at the centre of the saddle is about 6 m. Alongside and attached to the western side of the siphon is an expansion 2● m long and 7 m wide, forming a pool or structure, and divided by an internal wall into two unequal parts. The siphon duct links directly to the water collecting

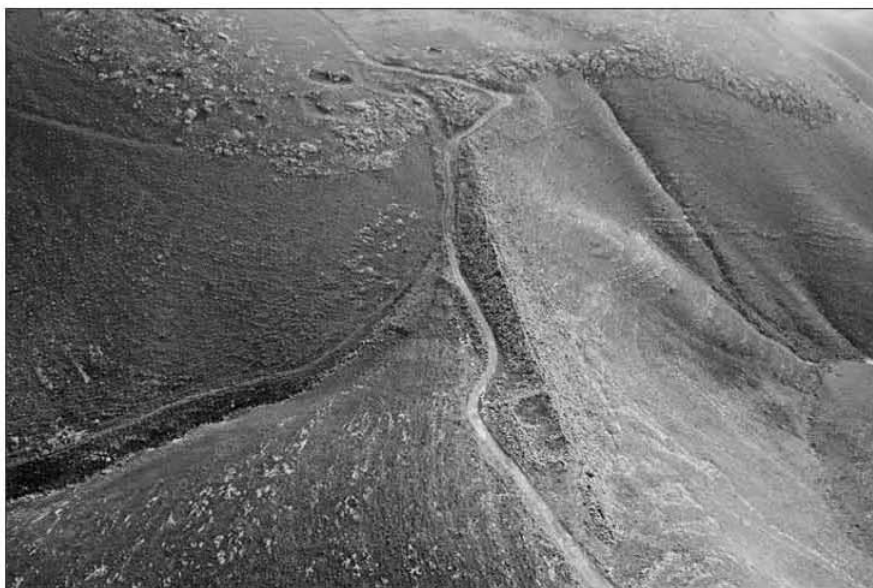


326. The Sartaba siphon, view to the east, 1993. In the foreground is the entry point of the aqueduct into the siphon (M. Einav).

channel in the west, which is clearly visible on the Quneitra extension. On the eastern side this connection was cut by a new unpaved road ascending to the Sartaba.

Many sherds were found in the area of the siphon and channel.

Pottery: Hellenistic – 70%; Early Roman – 30%.



327. Aerial view of the Sartaba siphon, view to the east, 2013 (A. Solomon).



328. One of the Sartaba cisterns, 1997 (M. Einav).

Site 172: 19-16/36/2

LOWER SARTABA

Israel grid: 1934/1668 (central)	Rock type: Avdat Group
UTM grid: 7320/5537 (central)	Soil type: stony-desert
Elevation: 310 m a.s.l., 0 m a.s.a.	Soil quality: 4
Name: nearest place	Cultivation: none
Site type: stone quarries and settlement	Cisterns: 4
Area: about 15 dunams (1.5 ha)	Water source: 'Ein el-Mana (176), 2 km distant
Topography: saddle surrounded by slopes	Road: roads C43-46, next to the site
	Visit: April 2001; 55 sherds

Quarries, settlement and supply base at the foot south-west of the Alexandrion fortress, in the broad saddle close to the west side of the aqueduct.

South-west of the fortress cone is a large area, about 600×300 m, which slopes down south to the cliffs above the siphon. Over this surface are various workings, all apparently linked to the fortress of Alexandrion, its foundation and maintenance:

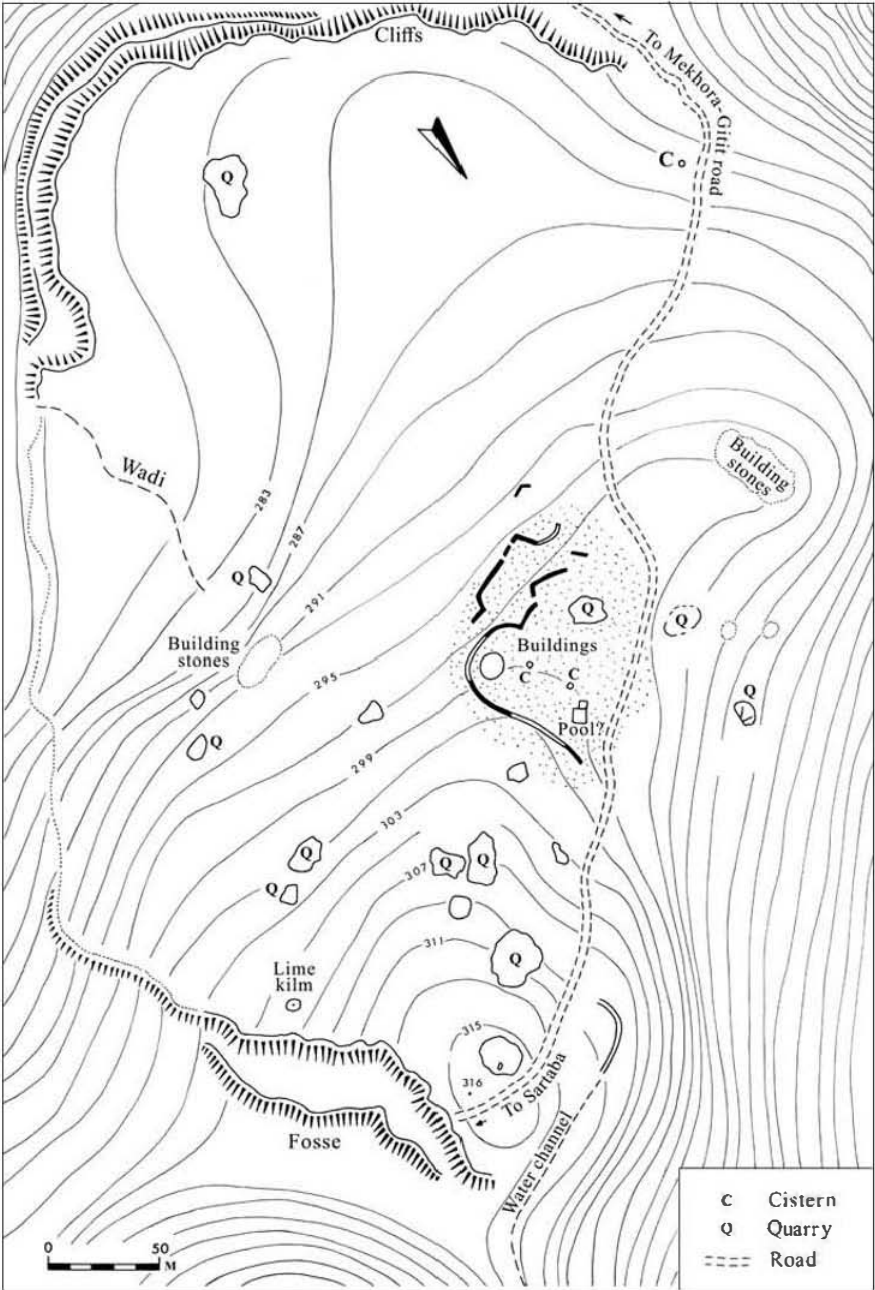
A. Quarries: in at least 50 locations over the surface of the saddle are quarrying marks in the rock, the source of building stones for the fortress. This area shows the following methods of quarrying:

A.1. Irregular large rock-hewn recesses, mostly oval or round, from 5 to 30 m across. Their average depth is about 1 m, and some are 2 m deep. These pits can be identified as remains of quarrying by their straight-cut edges, and it is apparent that stones were taken out from them. These recesses are spread all over the saddle, but their main concentration is in the western part, close to the Sartaba cliffs and the siphon area.

A.2. Grooves: cut into rock surfaces, into which wooden wedges were jammed and then wetted to expand and crack the rock. There are a few of these, mainly on the northern slope.

A.3. The moat: the western moat of the fortress, separating the Sartaba cone and the western saddle, is also a large quarry. It is about 30 m wide and about 10 m deep. Found in it were large building stones, some apparently rolled down from the fortress.

B. 'A quarrymen's village': in the northern part of the saddle, close to the new unpaved road and the aqueduct, is a small settlement, about 3 dunams (3000 sq. m) in area, containing 20 structures or remains of structures. The structures are poorly preserved, making it difficult to discern their plans without excavation. At the centre of the settlement are cisterns and a plastered pool. In our



329. Plan of Lower Sartaba, 2001.

opinion, the settlement served as a centre for the quarry workers and fortress builders, and was apparently abandoned once the fortress was finished; although it may have remained in use longer as a supply base. Another cistern is 100 m north-west of the settlement, but it is difficult to determine whether was related to the site.

C. The aqueduct: passes along the northern side of the saddle (for details see Site 171). Here it appears as a dug and built channel about 1 m wide. In most places the duct is ruined or blocked with silt, but it is still possible to follow its route. In certain places two phases (or two ducts) can be seen, one above the other.

Meshel (1989: 297) noticed the remains on the western plateau, describing it thus: "Over the area...are found relatively many remains, obviously, part of them recent: recesses and pits for drainage of local surface water, various lines of walls, pens for herds, etc. For example...south of the road we exposed, while searching for the dike, a plastered installation, *miqveh*-like (?), lines of walls, heaps of stones, a long line of a pen or terrace, and other finds. Here was apparently the main assembly area for the army besieging the fortress, and perhaps also the king's guard's encampment place when the king stayed in the fortress. At a high point on the western side of the plateau are, in our opinion, vague remains of an enclosure, possibly connected to our subject. However, the information available to us at this stage is insufficient to state anything firm."

Meshel's opinion that the platform served as the assembly area for every army intending to besiege the place is acceptable. Only here is a flat surface



330. Lower Sartaba (on the plateau west of Alexandrion Fortress), viewed to the east from the siphon, 1996 (M. Einav).

large enough for the purpose, with at least two roads leading to it, which then ascend to the fortress from this direction.

Pottery: Hellenistic – 80%; Early and Late Roman – 15%; Middle Ages – 5%.

Flint: 15 items, see Appendix A.

Additional surveys: none.

Additional Bibliography: Conder and Kitchener 1882: 397-398.



Site 173: 19-16/37/1

SARTABA FORTRESS

Israel grid: 1937/1670 (central)

UTM grid: 7323/5539 (central)

Elevation: 377 m a.s.l., 100 m a.s.a.

Name: ancient and on map

Site type: Fortress

Topography: high cone

Rock type: Avdat Group

Soil type: stony-desert

Soil quality: 2

Cultivation: none

Cisterns: 14

Water source: see site 171 above

Road: roads C43-46, next to the site

Visits: First visit 1993 and numerous repeated visits; 850 sherds

A fortress on a prominent topographical cone in the eastern part of the Sartaba plateau. The fortress is a complex compound, whose components are: 1. the Sartaba fortress; 2. the approach roads; 3. the water system (Site 171); 4. Lower Sartaba (the quarries and quarrymen's village – Site 172); and 5. the siege works (Site 165). Components 1 and 2 are discussed below; the others have been dealt with under their site numbers.

1. Alexandrion Fortress: the discussion comprises: A) description; B) history; C) travellers' descriptions and various other sources; D) excavations; E) newly raised aspects.

A) Description: Structures with various parts at the top of the Sartaba cone and its eastern slope, all belonging to the fortress complex. The main components are:

A.1. The summit: an elongated irregular surface, measuring about 95×40 m, with steep slopes down from it in all directions. It is divided into the southern area, in which a central structure stood, and the northern area, descending moderately from south to north. The summit is encircled by a wall, parts of which were found to the north-east and south-west of the summit. The surviving part of the enclosure wall is two stones wide, which is about 1 m, but it

seems originally to have been thicker. In the north-eastern part of the summit the wall seems to have been double, with a 5 m gap between the walls. The lower wall of the two was not actually discovered, and its supposed existence is deduced from the dyke it formed on the slope.

A.2. The northern surface of the summit: an oval area sloping north strewn with building stones. In its north-eastern part are the remains of the enclosure wall with a tower (?) or a structure at the higher end, commanding the slope. The stones from tower collapse lie in the higher part of the northern surface. Five large circular robbing pits were dug in the northern area. Three of them are grouped by the entrance in the central upper part of that area. The largest pit is about 9 m in diameter and about 1.5 m deep. A disorganized excavation is clearly visible, aimed, in our opinion, at finding significant structures. The dig exposed a thick wall built of ashlar, which was an element in the structures on the northern slope, and perhaps the entrance structure. Close by and east of the large pit are two pits, 6 and 5 m in diameter. They are about 1.5 m deep, and also contain building remains. A smaller pit is by the western wall, south of the presumed entrance, and there is another pit at the north of the area next to a robbing trench.

The robbing pits, like the excavation south-west of the southern structure on the summit, have not been mentioned in any scientific account. The British Survey (Conder and Kitchener 1882: 397) mentions them; from which we deduce that these are robbing digs conducted on the Sartaba summit by a European traveller in the first half of the 19th century. At that time the 'custom' of unregulated robbing excavations was common in various places, triggered by the discoveries in Egypt: however, there are other possibilities.

A.3. The southern structure on the summit: a rather small, 30×20 m, horizontally stepped structure. Three steps were exposed, the northern one about 20 m wide and the southern one about 6 m wide. They appear in plans by Abel (1913: Ill. 7) and Bar-Adon (1972: site 5). The only part of the structure exposed is the south-western edge, where a wall was discovered, and currently stands 2–3 m high (10 courses of large cut stones). Some of the stones have drafted margins and a boss; others are smooth ashlar, and the rest were originally bossed, but smoothed later. The construction is headers and stretchers, but in this also there is no uniformity.

The building has been badly damaged by an earthquake, and some of the walls are tilted sideways or downwards. The lack of uniformity in the cutting of the stones and in the laying of the headers and stretchers (Abel 1913: 229–230; Moulton 1936: 18) suggested to researchers that the wall is later than the Herodian era; but this is as yet unsubstantiated. Close to the south-western wall is a large excavation which exposed some of the walls and the southern part of the structure. From the look of the excavation it appears that it was not

scientific but a robbing dig. An excavation on the eastern side is shallower. It is not obvious who excavated and when: in a note Tsafirir and Magen (1984: 27) claimed that it originated in the first half of the 20th century; however, the British Survey (Conder and Kitchener 1882: 397) shows that it already existed in 1872. There is no doubt that this excavation took place after the earthquake which destroyed the building, because the fallen stones were taken out of the dig. The foundation trench of the structure and its root in the bedrock were exposed during this excavation. The measurements of the structure taken by various researchers at different times vary slightly, but its horizontally stepped construction is absolutely clear.

The volume of the collapse stones covering the remains of the southern structure indicates a very tall building, towering at least 10 m above the present level. Judging by the construction method and number of stones scattered over the slope, it is apparent that the southern structure served as sort of observation fort (or for another purpose) prominent above the summit, while the main area of the palace was on the eastern slope.

A.4. The eastern slope: the entire upper part of the eastern slope was apparently built up. Nowadays it is covered by a collapse heap of large stones, originating from the upper structure and structures on the slope. About 50 m below the upper tip of the cone were a large structure, excavated by Tsafirir's expedition (below - D), and a Herodian peristyle with heart-shaped columns.

A.5. The approach roads to the upper structure have not been preserved,



331. Aerial view of The Sartaba Fortress, view to the west, 1997. Note the cisterns and the setting of the site (M. Einav).

but it is apparent that stairs ascended to it from north and south. It could be surmised that such a system, or possibly a constructed pathway, ascended from north-west, more or less where the present path is. This is the most convenient approach from the western saddle and the moat. In the south, remains of stairs have been preserved; Meshel (1970: 105) reports other stairs coming from the Wadi Qurein road (C45).

B. History: the fortress was founded during the Hellenistic period, but there is no substantiated information as who was the founder. The name of the place is derived from the name of the wife of Alexander Jannaeus (103–76 BCE), Shlomzion (Salome) Alexandra (76–67 BCE). Its history can be divided into two: 1. A refuge fortress during the Hasmonean period; 2. A family prison and burial place in Herod's time.

B.1. The refuge fortress: The first mention appears in Ant. XIII, xvi: 3, while discussing Alexandra's deeds: "But still they themselves were to blame for their misfortunes, in allowing a woman to reign who madly desired it in her unreasonable love for power, and when her sons were in the prime of life. And so the Queen, not knowing what to do consistent with her dignity, entrusted to them the guarding of the fortresses with the exception of Hyrcania, Alexandreion and Machaerus, where her most valuable possessions were."

A slightly later piece of information (concerning the year 63 BCE) appears in War I, vi: 5 (and likewise in Ant. XIV, iii: 4): "Indignant at this behaviour, and yielding to the urgent entreaties of Hyrcanus and his friends, Pompey started



332. The southern projection of the horizontally stepped structure at the Sartaba Fortress, view to the north, 1996 (S. Hashman).

in pursuit of Aristobulus, with the Roman forces and a large contingent of Syrian auxiliaries. Passing Pella and Scythopolis, he reached Coreae, at which point a traveller ascending through the interior enters the territory of Judaea. There he heard that Aristobulus had taken refuge in Alexandreion, one of the lavishly equipped fortresses, situated on a high mountain, and sent orders to him to come down."

Further on there are notes regarding the negotiations between Aristobulus and Pompey, while Aristobulus alternately goes up and down the fortress (Ant. XIV, iii: 4).

Alexander, son of Aristobulus, fortified Alexandrion's walls (although there is no information of the walls having been damaged before then): "But some time later, while Alexander, the son of Aristobulus, was overrunning Judaea, Gabinius came to Syria from Rome as governor, and after achieving many other things of note, also marched against Alexander... (who) then went round the country and armed many of the Jews, and soon collected ten thousand heavily-armed soldiers and fifteen hundred horse, and fortified the strongholds of Alexandreion near Coreae and Machaerus near the mountains of Arabia. Gabinius therefore went out against him..." (Ant. XIV, v: 2; and likewise in War I, viii: 2)

The next piece of information deals with the war waged by Gabinius, the Roman commissioner left by Pompey (about 57 BCE), against Alexander: "With the remnant of his army he fled to Alexandreion. Gabinius, following him thither, found many of his men camping outside the walls. Before attacking them, he endeavoured, by promise of pardon for past offences, to bring them over to his side; but, on their proudly refusing all terms, he killed a large number of them and confined the remainder in the fortress... Leaving the reduction of the fort to his troops, Gabinius made a parade of the country, restoring order in the cities which had escaped devastation, and rebuilding those he found in ruins...After supervising these arrangements, Gabinius returned to Alexandreion and pressed the siege so vigorously that Alexander, despairing of success, sent him a herald with a petition for pardon for his offences and an offer to surrender the fortresses of Hyrcania and Machaerus, still in his possession; subsequently he gave up Alexandreion as well. All these places Gabinius demolished, to prevent their serving as a base of operations for another war. He was instigated to take this step by Alexander's mother, who had come to propitiate him, in her concern for her husband and remaining children, then prisoners in Rome." (War I, viii: 3-5; and likewise in Ant. XIV, v: 3-4).

Alexander, who later fled from Rome "...began by seizing Alexandreion and attempting to restore the fortifications; but on hearing that Gabinius had dispatched an army against him... he retreated toward Machaerus." (War I, viii:

6; and likewise in Ant. XIV, vi: 1)

B.2. Imprisonment and burial place during Herod's reign: the second chapter in the history of the fortress is connected to Herod I 'The Great' (37 BCE – 4 CE), who rebuilt the fortress as part of the inheritance struggle between himself and Antigonus: "He (Herod) instructed Pheroras, his youngest brother... to fortify Alexandreion." (War I, xvi: 3; and likewise in Ant. XIV, xv: 4). This information is dated to 39/38 BCE.

In 30/29 BCE, when the strife within the House of Herod escalated, resulting from the envy of the daughters of the Hasmonean family in Edom who rose to prominence, the king imprisoned his wife Miriam and her mother in the fortress: "As for his wife Mariamme – since it was impossible for her to live in the same place because of the quarrel between her and his mother and sister - he placed her in Alexandreion with her mother Alexandra, leaving in charge there his steward Joseph and Soemus the Ituraean... And they, too, were given instructions that if they learned that anything bad had happened to him, they were to dispose of both women at once..." (Ant. XV, vi: 5).

When Marcus Agrippa visited the land (15 BCE) Herod hosted him: "...in the fortresses which he had built at great expense, Alexandreion, Herodion and Hyrcania." (Ant. XVI, ii: 1).

The last chapter in the history of Herod's fortress is linked to one of the most tragic events in the dynasty's history: Herod's murder of his sons by Miriam – Alexander and Aristobulus. The event begins with a faked letter of accusation from Alexander to the commander of Alexandrion, who was tortured but refused to give false evidence (War I, xxvi: 3; Ant. XVI, x: 4). This event ended when: "...Alexander and Aristobulus were taken to Sebaste and at the command of their father were killed by strangling. During the night their bodies were laid away in Alexandreion, where their maternal grandfathers and most of their ancestors were buried." (Ant. XVI, xi: 7).

Thus, during Herod's reign, the fortress served as a family prison, a guest house and a magnificent necropolis for the Hasmonean family.

The latest information (in the Mishnah, 3rd century CE) mentions the Sartaba as a station for lighting beacons between Jerusalem and the Babylonian diaspora, notifying the sighting of the New Moon – *Rosh-Hodesh*: "And from where did they light the flares? From the Mount of Olives to Sarteba, and from Sarteba to Agrippina, and from Agrippina to Hāvan, and from Hāvan to Bet Biltin; and from Bet Biltin they did not move, but he waved to and fro and he raised and lowered until he would see the whole Diaspora before him like a mass of fire." (Rosh Hashanah, chapter 2, Mishnah 4 [Kehati 1990: 25]). The next stations were across the Jordan and on to Babylon. In the source quoted above the name Sartaba and not Alexandrion appears for the first time.

A puzzling item of information appears in the *Midrash Vayisau*, in its

original form probably dated not later than the Bar-Kokhba War (Schmitt 1983: 48; Strack and Stemberger 1991: 360-361), concerning the city of Zarethan (mentioned in Josh 3, 16; 1 Kgs 4, 12; 7, 46): "On the second day they went to Sarethan and here too they had a great war with them (the Canaanites). (It was) a high city on a high mound... and it was impossible to be defeated." (Yalkut Shim'oni, Bereshit, Vayishlahk XIII, p. LXII).

C. Travellers' descriptions and various other sources: from the many informative descriptions of the fortress, we have chosen those from the 19th and the beginning of the 20th century. Due to their abundance, only those containing a fresh contribution to the description and understanding of the place are included. Because of the poor outer state of preservation of the remains and the lack of excavation, there are not many of these: most of the visitors focus on the historical aspects, which will not be repeated.

Robinson (1970, III: 293-294) mentions the fortress, claiming to have visited it, but it seems be no substance to this. On May 11th 1857 he observed eastward from the village of Duma, writing the following: "The long, high, rocky ridge of the Surtabeh was over against us on the left...on its highest part is the horn not unlike that of a rhinoceros in form. Beyond this is a large shoulder; and then a low rocky ridge reaching almost down to the Jordan (to the *Ghor*, A. Z.)... The people here and elsewhere spoke of ruins somewhere on Surtabeh, and a reservoir for water; to which there was formerly an aqueduct from Nabulus! I examined the summit long and carefully with one of Plossl's *Feldstecher*; but

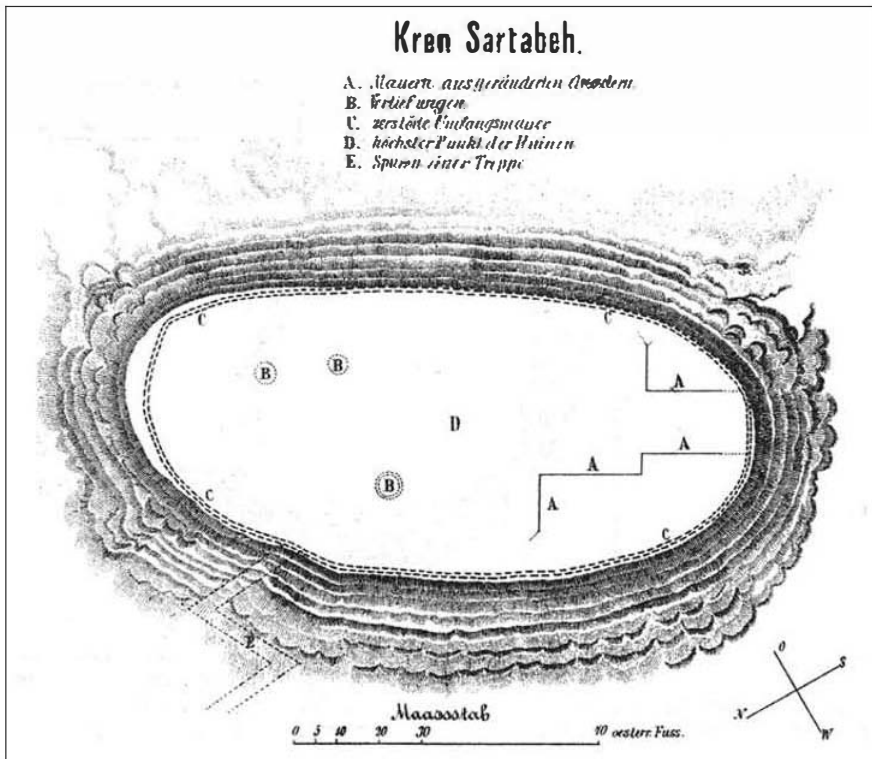


333. Aerial view of the Sartaba Fortress, view to the east, 2013 (A. Solomon).

could discover no appearance of ruins; more especially not upon the horn. The distance on an air line could hardly have been more than two or two and a half miles."

On 5 March 1874 Clermont-Ganneau (1874: 173-178) wrote a long letter that deals clearly with the meaning of the name Sartaba, but does not mention a visit to the place.

On 21 March 1874 the member of the British Survey, Colonel Tyrwhitt Drake (1874: 189-190) reports: "Kurn Sartabeh: Between this camp at Wady Fusail and our present one (Wadi Far'ah) is a very remarkable conical hill called Kurn Sartabeh, or Horn of Sartabeh, who, according to the Arabs, was an ancient king who built the castle there. He is by some called Sabartalah. This horn or peak is a very prominent point, and visible from Hermon and from Moab, as well as from many places on both the eastern and the western hills. It rises about 1,500 feet above sea level, and consequently is 2,500 feet higher than the Jordan at this part of its course. An old path zigzags up a ridge from the south, and by this we rode up. To the west of the peak a ruined aqueduct...A very steep ascent of 270 feet from this western ditch brought us to the top, where



334. Sartaba Fortress, the summit plan by Zschokke (1866).

are solid masses of masonry with drafted stones having irregular rustic bosses, and varying in length from two to three and a half feet by two feet in height... The stones employed in the construction (of the central construction – namely the fortress) are hard marbly limestone, seemingly dolomite, and very heavy. The labour of bringing them up to such a position must have been very great, as the nearest point from which they could have been hewn is nearly a mile distant.”

On 25 April 1874 Guérin (1969: 245) visited the place and gave a detailed report. He describes the peak of the fortress as being encircled by a wall built of huge stones, with flattened faces or ashlar, some of which are laid cross-wise and some lengthwise. Those whose contacting surfaces are flawless are not cemented; between those which are less perfectly matched all cracks are filled with small stone splinters stuck with clay which served as cement. He reports that from this fortress only the southern part is still standing; it ends with a square tower encircled by a moat. From this tower, with some of its lower courses still *in situ*, the general nature of the construction, which was carried out with great diligence, can be inferred. He adds that the entire north and central part of the fort had collapsed, and there is only a gigantic heap of large stones. Guérin also mentions that the locals call these ruins Kharbet El-Kala'h and that referring to the two summits, Jebel Sartaba is also called Kournein Sarthabeh or Sarthabeh Bou-Kournein – Sartaba father of the two horns.

The members of the British Survey visited on 2 and 5 March, and 3 April, 1874 and described it thus: “Kurn Surtubeh (P p). – The ruins on the summit of this mountain consist of a central structure with surrounding wall...The top of the mountain is a cone, artificially shaped...and some 270 feet high. On all sides but the west this is practically unapproachable: on the west a trench has been cut, and the saddle thus made lower. The slope of the sides is about 35°. The top measures 90 feet east and west, and 258 feet north and south, being an oval. The foundation measures 92 feet 9 inches along a line 189°, and 40 feet 6 inches at right angles. There is a set-back on the south-west of 14 feet for 26 feet 9 inches. A wall runs south from this foundation for 18 feet, being 20 feet 6 inches across. The outer rampart, now merely a mound, is 30 feet across, and covered with fallen masonry, as is also the eastern slope of the hill. The foundation consists of 10 courses of masonry, the stones placed in alternate courses of headers and stretchers, and varying from 1.5 feet to 4 feet in length, the height of the course being 1 foot 10 inches. They have drafts from 3.5 to 6 inches broad, and the boss is left rustic, with a projection in some cases of 5 inches. Forty-four feet from the north end of the central foundation are two excavations or pits sunk in the soft rock, where are traces as if of the effects of fire kindled at some time in them. The building seems to have been struck by

lightning, or perhaps shaken by earthquake, and the side of the tel on the east, for some 200 feet down, is strewn thickly with fallen ashlar, rather smaller than that of the foundation. The general appearance of the place is that of a fortress, with an oval outer *enceinte* and a central tower or keep, the foundations alone remaining. The masonry (which is of a hard crystalline limestone found on the ridge) is worked like that of the foundations at 'Athlit', and may possibly be Crusading. The mention of a castle here in the fourteenth century also favours this idea, as does the Arab tradition." (Conder and Kitchener 1882: 396-397).

Paul Sejourne (1895: 613-616), who visited the site in 1895, mentioned the rock-cut moat, the altitude on the cone and above the Rift Valley, the dimensions of the summit (80 paces in length and 25 in breadth), and he remarked that the construction should be related to the Roman era. He was so impressed by the view that he said that perhaps it was the most beautiful in the whole of the Land.

On 10 February 1910 Abel (1913: 227-234) visited the fortress. He mentioned the steep ascent to the Sartaba, the rhombus shape of the artificial summit, and its dimensions (100×40 m). He remarked that stones of the fortified wall in the southern part were worked either by smoothed cutting or coarse drafted margins with prominent bosses. He described the enclosure wall that surrounds the remains of the fortress, and he remarked on the dimensions of some of the stones – some are 1.06×0.47 m, others are 1.36×0.58 m, the boss protruded up to 0.06 m, and the width of the margins was 0.12 m. Abel also remarked that the Sartabah cone had been visited by a handful of researchers, and that Nathanael Schmidt's exploration in 1905 supplemented the British Survey work, resulting in the monograph 'Alexandrian' (Schmidt 1910). In a special article, Abel (1946) also tried to discover the location of the burial of Herod's sons.

On 10 October 1935 ten participants in an expedition of the American School of Oriental Research ascended the Sartaba, among them C.S. Fisher and W. F. Albright. Amongst their remarks should be noted the verification of identification of Alexandrian in the Sartaba (against the opinion of Robinson and Smith). Taking into account the state of the remains, the following remarks are significant:

1. "...we have a depression before the walls that may have been part of a small moat encircling this lofty stronghold. At first sight one might regard this simply as a hollow due to excavation, since it appears strange that the walls above, where cast down by earthquake, lightning, or the hands of men, should all have toppled in other directions. Elsewhere on the summit the debris effectually conceals whatever may be below." (Moulton 1936: 14).
2. All the pottery is from the 2nd century BCE to the 1st century CE (Moulton